

The Political Roots of Legal Access: Evidence from Village Councils in India*

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Abstract

Politicians have long served as intermediaries for citizens navigating the state. Can elected members of village councils facilitate citizens' access to the formal justice system? Justice seekers face social and administrative costs that cause most grievances to remain outside the state's purview. Council members lower these barriers through a distinct form of assistance: by exercising oversight and acting as intermediaries. I test this theory in 28,000 village councils in Maharashtra, India, leveraging population-based discontinuities in council size, paired with an original dataset of 3.36 million court cases. I find that additional council members lead to a 51% increase in case filings and use qualitative data to document direct interactions. Surveys of citizens and council elections data show that this phenomenon is explained by greater capacity and descriptive representation in larger councils. These findings reveal how political institutions act as a catalyst for legal mobilization.

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1 Introduction

Citizens across the world face significant barriers to justice: globally, over two-thirds of the population has unmet civil and criminal justice needs (World Justice Project [2019](#)). As legal issues remain unresolved, individuals risk losing their livelihoods, property, and fundamental human rights. Access to justice is therefore critical for protecting these rights and maintaining social stability—and courts form the central institutions where grievances can be resolved.

These grievances range from everyday justice issues, such as land disputes, to severe instances of crime and corruption. However, the vast majority of grievances face a series of obstacles before they reach the courts, leaving vulnerable citizens outside the protection of the rule of law. Faced with these barriers, citizens seek guidance from the most proximate state authority—typically, an elected representative. Although elected officials have long acted as intermediaries for citizens navigating the state (Stokes et al. [2013](#)), this paper offers new evidence on how they also play a critical role in helping citizens access the formal justice system.

Empirically identifying whether elected officials engage in this type of work is challenging. While surveys can capture individual experiences with the justice system, the small subset of the population engaged in disputes makes it difficult to generate representative samples. Further, endogenous factors—like litigants’ social capital and geographical proximity—determines whether they approach courts. I overcome these limitations by combining a novel administrative dataset with a regression discontinuity design (RDD) focused on Maharashtra, India. First, I assemble an original dataset of 3.36 million cases, that allows me to precisely measure legal access at the village level for 1.2 million cases. These cases are filed in the subordinate judiciary that is under the District Courts of Maharashtra: the courts of first instance in the state. Second, my identification strategy exploits a unique rule where two additional elected officials are assigned to the councils at strict, population-based cutoffs, providing a source of exogenous variation in the size of the council. The Indian context is also substantively important, given that citizens face multiple stages of discretion and discrimination as they seek to access formal state institutions (Jassal [2024](#)).

I find that increasing the size of the council increases access to the justice system. Specifically, I find that the case filing rate increases from a baseline of 1.19 to 1.79—corresponding to a 51% increase.

Further, I use the rich metadata associated with each case to determine whether a case involves a civil or criminal issue. I find similar sized effects for both criminal and civil cases—while the number of criminal cases increases by 41%, the number of civil cases increases by 64%. Finally, I use information on case decisions to show that political influence is limited to the filing stage of a case but cannot determine its timely adjudication.

I carry out tests to ensure that these results are not sensitive to the choice of bandwidth, districts in the sample and functional form assumptions. I obtain consistent results in employing three alternate empirical strategies: (i) by leveraging a regression discontinuity aggregation (RDA) design (Borusyak and Kolerman-Shemer 2025) that allows me to include cases filed by litigants from multiple villages, with treatments defined at the sub-district level; (ii) extending the RD results by accounting for possible missing cases by leveraging the serialized nature of the case numbers (Wu et al. 2026) and (iii) by leveraging a natural experiment involving newly formed councils.

I supplement the quantitative analysis drawing upon two distinct sets of qualitative data that highlight the ways in which council members facilitate access to the justice system. First, informational interviews with 19 council members confirm that council members employ different strategies to deal with civil and criminal issues in their village and serve as intermediaries. Second, a coding of field notes from shadowing council presidents (Bussell 2020b) provide evidence on how the officials exercise oversight to ensure that citizens' complaints are recorded by the police.

I proceed to explore the supply and demand side mechanisms underscoring the increase in legal access. The literature on state capacity shows that the supply of political, bureaucratic and judicial resources can lead to large immediate and downstream benefits. Such increases in state capacity is based on the both the number and type of officials. This idea extends as a driver of legal access: a larger council increases legal access by increasing the number of officials who can assist with legal grievances, and the identity of elected officials that shapes their responsiveness.

To test these patterns, I assemble additional data on council elections, council members, election timing, the census and two surveys: the Rural Demographic and Economic Survey of India (REDS-2006) and the Indian Human Development Survey (IHDS-2011).

I leverage a natural experiment within the REDS-2006 to show that respondents in villages with larger

councils had better evaluations of council members' quality and problem-solving ability—increasing the size of the council increases its capacity to serve citizens. Further, I use rich data on council elections (Amar 2025) and find that larger councils have greater descriptive representation of non-dominant groups—villages with additional seats elect more women and members of marginalized groups, in excess of those accounted by mandatory reservation policies or quotas.

A larger council can also increase the demands for assistance, by affecting the number and types of citizens that are requesting assistance. I show suggestive evidence of this by demonstrating greater political mobilization in larger councils: I find that larger councils increase voter turnout by 21%. Importantly, this increased representation and mobilization is consequential and leads to substantive representation—I find that larger councils lead to an increase in the filing rate for women and members of non-dominant groups.

I also evaluate three alternative explanations that could explain why increasing the size of the council increases legal access. First, larger councils could increase the electoral competitiveness, which in turn increases the responsiveness of council members (Gerring and Veenendaal 2020). However, I find no evidence that the treatment affects electoral competitiveness. Second, larger councils could change the provision of public goods, particularly those related to the police. Particularly, council members could influence the staffing of the village-level law enforcement officer: however, I show that the smaller and larger sized councils are not systematically different in terms of whether the village police position is filled or not. Finally, a larger council could signal better state capacity and increase trust in state institutions (Hansen 2013). Descriptive analysis using citizen surveys from the IHDS-2011 (Table A10) suggest that the size of the council is not associated with confidence in the police and courts.

The findings in this paper underscore how local institutions can shape legal behaviors in weak states (Blattman, Hartman, and Blair 2014; Brulé 2020). Crucially, this paper challenges the assumption that local authorities undermine the rule of law. Instead, I show how non-adjudicative political institutions can strengthen formal adjudicative institutions by lowering the barriers to entry (Sarat and J. B. Grossman 1975).

Prior research has noted the role of elected officials as local intermediaries, shaping the allocation of benefits (Besley, Pande, Rahman, et al. 2004; Besley, Pande, and V. Rao 2012; Chattopadhyay

and Duflo [2004](#); Dunning and Nilekani [2013](#)), access to the state and its resources (Bussell [2019](#); Kruks-Wisner [2018a](#)), and their contribution to democratic processes (Besley, Pande, and V. Rao [2005](#); Parthasarathy, V. Rao, and Palaniswamy [2019](#)). I contribute to these studies by highlighting how politicians play a role in helping citizens access legal institutions. I do so by assembling a massive dataset encompassing the cases filed in the lower-most courts of the judiciary in Maharashtra, and contribute to the growing body of scholarship that examines the dynamic interplay between law and society at the grassroots level (Galanter and Dhavan [1989](#); Goyal, Van Noort, and Ahrenshop [2022](#); Kokal [2019](#); J. K. Krishnan et al. [2014](#)).

Finally, this article also contributes to a broad literature examining how a specific factor of institutional design—the size of the elected body—affects electoral and governance outcomes. Previous work has primarily focused on the effect of legislature size on fiscal policy and public goods provision (Chen and Malhotra [2007](#); Höhmann [2017](#); Lewis [2019](#); Mignozzetti, Cepaluni, and Freire [2024](#); Pettersson-Lidbom [2012](#); Weingast, Shepsle, and Johnsen [1981](#)), I extend this literature by investigating its effects on non-mandated forms of assistance. Given that elected officials can facilitate citizens’ ability to make legal claims, I show that facilitating access to justice can be a form of deliverable political good (Gallagher, Kruks-Wisner, and Taylor [2024](#)).

2 Theoretical Expectations

Accessing justice is a broad concept, widely linked to the protection of human rights, social stability and economic development (Deseau, Levai, and Schmiegelow [2025](#)). While citizens often turn to customary and informal institutions to resolve disputes, state courts remain essential to conflict resolution as decisions are adhered to and enforced by codified laws. However, physical and social barriers frequently prevent citizens from reaching the formal judicial institutions. Overcoming these barriers is the critical first step in realizing justice, as this initial mobilization enables formal adjudicative institutions to interpret and manage conflict (Sarat and J. B. Grossman [1975](#)).

Each stage of legal mobilization is costly: would-be litigants constantly weigh the payoffs of pursuing claims, meaning only a fraction of problems enter the formal system (Genn [1999](#); Sandefur [2019](#)). This disproportionately affects rural litigants, who endure greater barriers in getting their legal

needs met (A. Hoffman and Strezhnev 2023; J. K. Krishnan et al. 2014). To address this problem, a growing body of literature highlights the role of local institutions which can facilitate access to justice. These localized solutions take various form, such as relying on “justice workers” in the United States (Sandefur and Burnett 2024), transferring legal authority to village heads (Clark and Stephens 2011), or establishing community courts (Andemariam 2011). Indeed, the comparative literature has highlighted the role of communities and village-level authorities in dispute resolution (Baldwin and Ricart-Huguet 2023; Ellickson 1994; Galanter 1981; Gauri 2009; Just 2001; Van Der Waal 2004), less is known about the role of local intermediaries who can help citizens bridge the gap to the formal legal system.

Elected officials can exercise political oversight and act as intermediaries, by offering assistance at various stages as an aggrieved party navigates the bureaucracy of legal and law enforcement institutions to register formal complaints. First, politicians exercise oversight—the ability to hold bureaucrats accountable—when they have the capacity to monitor and sanction bureaucratic behaviors (Raffler 2022). They can also intervene and motivate bureaucratic performance (Gulzar and B. J. Pasquale 2017). Second, politicians act as intermediaries by serving as informal advisors who offer advice and assistance in navigating the legal system. Ultimately, both channels can increase citizens’ access to the justice system.

These processes operate in distinct ways depending on whether the grievance is criminal or civil. Accessing the criminal justice system requires citizens to first approach the law enforcement institutions, which can often be dismissive towards complaints. Consequently, for criminal grievances, elected officials can rely on exercising political oversight to hold bureaucrats in the law enforcement system accountable.

On the other hand, civil grievances—such as those involving family disputes, land boundaries or debt—are amenable to mediation because they rely on local knowledge and social consensus. In these cases, the elected officials can initially play a quasi-judicial role, counseling the parties and negotiating a resolution (Sarat and J. B. Grossman 1975). However, if such mediation fails, elected officials can facilitate access to the legal system by bridging informational gaps.

While this work allows politicians to claim credit and signal competency, it is constrained by their capacity and incentives. First, greater capacity—politicians with better networks, with more time

and resources at their disposal—can lead to greater assistance (Callen et al. 2025). Second, electoral incentives could shape *when* assistance is provided, as representatives stand to gain more through credit-claiming at the time of elections (King 1991). Third, partisan and identity-based motivations can make them prioritize assistance for their core supporters, as opposed to the broader public.

Indeed, identity-based assistance is a form of substantive representation (Pitkin 1967, p. 155): identities can determine who makes demands *and* who receives the assistance. Citizens do not uniformly demand assistance (G. Grossman and Slough 2022): shared identities play an important role in whether the help is requested in the first place. Once help is requested, shared identities shape responsiveness: representatives are more responsive towards citizens with whom they share identifiable characteristics (Broockman 2013; Butler and Broockman 2011; Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004). Consequently, the provision of legal assistance can be shaped by identities.

Although the theory focuses on elected representatives, it applies more broadly to other non-elected intermediaries with strong incentives to provide legal access to citizens. Examples of such intermediaries include village elders, brokers, state officials and “new leaders” (Krishna 2011). It applies to contexts where individuals have strong connections to their elected representatives. The theory focuses on how elected officials help citizens overcome individual-level hurdles for dispute resolutions through courts. This is distinct from larger patterns of mobilization of social and political movements, wherein incentives of elected officials are not entirely clear.

Finally, while the theory applies to the registration of disputes, resolution of formalized disputes is not guaranteed. Elected officials cannot influence case resolution if courts are adequately shielded from interference and oversight. Thus, while elected officials can influence the whether citizens are able to approach legal and law enforcement institutions, they cannot influence the outcomes and resolutions beyond this step.

3 Context: Village Councils in Maharashtra, India

Through the 73rd amendment to the Constitution, the Government of India formalized a uniform system of decentralization that created elected bodies beyond the national and state legislatures to the third tier of government. The reform created a three-tier system of local governance comprising

zilla panchayats (district-level bodies), *taluka panchayats* (sub-district level bodies) and *gram panchayats* (village-level bodies). This paper focuses on the village-level bodies in Maharashtra, India. Maharashtra is a large state in the western part of India with a population of 112 million, and is divided into 36 administrative districts. Each district is divided into 358 sub-districts (*Talukas*). The sub-districts are further divided into 28,000 councils or *Gram Panchayats*, each of which typically consists of a single village, or 2-3 small villages.

The council consists of a *pradhan* (council head) and the ward members, who are elected for a period of five years. Ward members are directly elected; in recent years, the council head has been elected through direct and indirect elections (Alyssa René Heinze 2025). These positions are not term limited, however, India's reservation system or 'quotas' applies to each of these position. This involves reservation of 50% of seats for women, and a percent of seats are reserved for members belonging to the Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST) and Other Backward Classes (OBC) in proportion of their population.

The 73rd amendment formally entrusted the councils with both administrative and developmental functions. These functions involved activities like managing and monitoring facilities for water provision, sanitation, education, and public health (Chaudhary and Iyer 2022).¹ Councils are also carry out essential tasks involved in implementing numerous public policies and programs, notably the world's largest employment program, guaranteeing 100 days of minimum-wage employment and the construction and maintenance of roads (Brulé 2020; Bussell 2019; Gulzar, Haas, and B. Pasquale 2020).

In addition to these mandated responsibilities, prior research has noted council members play an informal role in facilitating citizens' access to the state. As navigating the Indian bureaucracy is plagued by complex procedures and demands for "speed-money" (bribes), citizens frequently rely on political networks and intermediaries for assistance (Berenschot 2010; Chauchard 2017). Indeed, 62% of survey respondents reported contacting council members for help to make claims on the state (Kruks-Wisner 2018b). Although higher level officials can be approached, citizens routinely identify the village-level council members as the figures best equipped to help them access the

¹Maharashtra has one of the highest rankings regarding actual devolution of power to the councils (Unnikrishnan 2016), and is one of the few states with effective councils and regular elections before the 73rd Amendment (Chaudhary and Iyer 2022).

services they need (Bussell 2019).

Assisting citizens who face disputes and offences is a part of this informal role. India has a long tradition of dispute resolution at the village level— Meschievitz and Galanter (1982) explain that the term *panchayat* literally means the ‘coming together of five persons,’ and the meeting of five or more members of a village or caste to judge disputes was a prevalent practice in the past.²

Today, this role appears to have transformed: wherein elected officials help citizens navigate the justice system, through courts and the police (Singh 2022, p. 8). The support begins at the initial stage of the issue: a nationwide survey found that 23% of respondents would approach members of the village council and 49% would consult village elders for advice.³ As disputes escalate, officials in both rural and urban areas mediate relations with the law enforcement system (Bussell 2019; Tellez, Wibbels, and Krishna 2020). In fact, 6-9% of council members report that help with police cases is the most common type of assistance requested (Bussell 2019, p. 59), since the police have considerable leeway in which complaints are formally registered (Jassal 2024).

Beyond cases involving the police, council members function as essential intermediaries for would-be litigants. For instance, they play a key role in issuing documents necessary for land transactions and inheritance—which are used as evidence in courts (Chauchard 2017, p. 17). Ethnographies of courts and interviews with litigants lend further support to this.⁴ A litigant in district court shared that she only filed her case in court “because of the support and co-operation of the *sarpanch* (elected panchayat leader)”. A second litigant noted that the locally elected official helped her in gathering documents related to her land for the dispute. A third emphasized their role in navigating through

²These bodies could be organized along caste lines, based on village boundaries or involve the members of trade guilds or artisan groups to formally or informally hear complaints. While the idea of village panchayats serving as “judiciaries of the village” is not new, the Government of India has tried to approach the challenge of access to justice through two routes. In 2006, the Ministry of Panchayati Raj of the Government of India announced the formation of a committee to prepare a ‘Nyaya Panchayat Draft Bill’, which would involve elected bodies to serve as adjudicators. Press reports suggest that the Law Ministry had expressed objections to this, since in the same period (in 2007), the Ministry of Justice and Law conceptualized the *gram nyayalays*—which decentralizes judicial responsibility to local (village) level judicial bodies in the form of “mobile courts” that are headed by judicial officers who are trained judges (as opposed to elected officials). The ‘Gram Nyayalays Bill’ was eventually passed in 2008 in both houses of the Parliament. While few remain operational, these so-called village-level courts are simply reassigned courtrooms located within existing subordinate courts, thus their title is nominal (Bail 2015).

³*Access to Justice Survey*—conducted by Daksh India—employed random sampling and collected responses from over 50,000 individuals. The information gathered includes demographic data, perceptions regarding disputes and information on disputes resolved through courts and through non-judicial means.

⁴All quotes from J. Krishnan et al. (2014): a team of researchers conducted rich ethnographies of courts in three Indian states.

the process: “The elected representative of my village are very cooperative. They help us resolve problems and guide us in court matters too”.

While help in facilitating filings is itself meaningful, accessing justice in the Indian courts is a separate matter, and has been referred to as a “lifelong nightmare” (Yasir 2024). Courts in India are incredibly overloaded—on a per capita basis, India has only 20 judges per million⁵, while the United States has over 100 and Europe has over 200 judges per million (M. Rao 2024). Similarly, the Indian police system is also one of the most under-resourced—India has the second lowest police-to-population ratio in the world (Lee 2021). Consequently, India’s legal system is notoriously slow—congested courts delay the resolution of even minor cases.

The judiciary in India is organized as a three-tier system: with the Supreme Court at the center, 24 state-level High Courts, and 700 District Courts. I focus on the lowest tier of the district courts: the subordinate courts *under* the District Courts, which form the courts of first instance. These courts hears both civil and criminal cases, and form the first point of contact between citizens and the justice system.

4 Data and Empirical Strategy

4.1 Data

Case-level data from Maharashtra District Courts: The main variable of interest is access to the justice system—whether people approach courts to enforce their legal rights. This is measured by using administrative data on the universe of reported civil and criminal complaints handled by District Courts, the courts of first instance in India.

The primary source of this data is the eCourts project, which was designed to strengthen India’s justice delivery by facilitating digital filings and availability of up-to-date judicial records. It involved a large-scale digitization of cases, which were made accessible to the public through a web-based platform. Each case record captures key details in its metadata, which includes the date of filing, acts and sections under which the case was filed, police station responsible (in case of criminal cases),

⁵Judges are recruited based on their performance in competitive judicial examinations, the norms for which vary across states.

and details of the actors involved (which are the litigants, lawyers and judges). Additionally each case record captures the processing details during the lifetime of the case: indicating the hearings conducted, interim orders (if any), whether a decision has been reached, and occasionally, the text of the judgment.

The main advantage of using this dataset is that the case filings capture whether individuals *meaningfully* accessed the justice system. Pursuing civil litigation in India involves the payment of processing fees and submitting a draft of the complaint to the court. Pursuing criminal litigation in India involves approaching the police, who file charges against the accused and conduct investigations before sending the case to a court (Jassal 2024).

While the eCourts data directly measures access to the civil justice system, measuring the legal registration of criminal cases that reach the courts serves as a hard test for the theory, since cases need to be registered by the police and also forwarded to the criminal justice system. While case filings only considers the complaints that reach courts, a limitation of using this as an outcome is that we cannot capture if council members are facilitating greater access to other stages in helping citizens access the justice system.

The case-level data includes 3.36 million cases scraped from the state’s public-facing website.⁶ These are the cases filed in the subordinate courts—that is, the Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class courts. Cases filed in subordinate courts involve small sums of money and shorter sentences⁷. The case-level metadata in Maharashtra includes the location from where the complaint originated: for rural areas, this is a census village from the 2001 census. A simple case coding rule (elaborated in Table A2) classifies cases as a civil or criminal case. I create a panel dataset of village-year observations, with outcomes that include counts of all case filings, civil filings and criminal filings between 2016 and 2022 standardized by the village population to compute filing rates.

I restrict the main analysis to a 1.2 million of the 3.36 million cases (36% of cases in the subordinate courts) in which all parties associated with a case belong to the same village⁸ and show robustness

⁶District Courts, Maharashtra https://court.mah.nic.in/courtweb/index_eng.php#, Last Accessed in December 2023 after which the data (without the village-level identifiers) can be accessed from the national eCourts repository.

⁷Further details in Section A.6

⁸I make these restrictions for two reasons: first, I expect my theory to apply to cases where all parties are from the

by conducting an analysis of all cases filed from multiple villages using an alternate empirical strategy in Table [A13](#).

Village Councils: A village-level council is constituted for a single revenue village in Maharashtra; however, some councils span two or three villages. I identify a universe of over 28,000 councils from the Local Government Directory, an official dataset that maps rural government boundaries to India’s census data. I merge this with the *MahaEgram* dataset managed by the Rural Development and Panchayat Raj Department of the Government of Maharashtra. Because *MahaEgram* tracks each councils’ establishment date, geographic area and public facilities, I can use it to focus on subsets of councils that are created before 2011. Finally, I use village-level census identifiers to link these records to the Rural-Urban Geographic Platform for India (or SHRUG). This allows me to integrate data from the 2001 and 2011 Census on village and council-level demographics.

Council Elections Data: I collected data on elections conducted in each council from the Maharashtra State Election Commission’s website. The earliest election recorded on the website is from 2017, and data were scraped up to the 2022 elections. This contains information on candidates, winners, winning margins and turnout. Additionally, I use the data on the profiles and quotas in council elections in 2021 from the Maharashtra State Election Commission (Amar [2025](#)) to test mechanisms.

Survey Data: I use two sources of survey data to capture citizens’ opinions. First, I use data from the National Council of Applied Economics Rural Economic and Demographic Survey (REDS)—the survey collects data from a nationally representative sample from over 8,659 households in 240 rural villages in 17 Indian states on questions of local governance.⁹ Second, I use data from the Indian Human Development Survey (IHDS-2011)—a nationally representative sample of over 42,152 households—to capture citizens’ evaluations of confidence and trust in legal and law enforcement institutions.

same village. Second, cases that arise from multiple villages cannot be used since the treatment status (described in the empirical strategy in Section [4.2](#)) cannot be determined for such cases. The village of the party is determined by the address of the plaintiff and defendant filed in the system—these can be individuals or organizations. For criminal cases, if there are three accused, the addresses of all three will be entered in the system. Although the state is a “party” to the case, an address for the state is not entered in this case.

⁹Data has been generously shared by Andrew Foster.

4.2 Empirical Strategy

In this section, I describe the empirical strategy to test H_1 : whether increasing the size of the council increases access to the formal justice system. A challenge to testing whether the additional council members increase access to the justice system is that councils with more members may be systematically different from those that have fewer members. For example, villages with a larger number of council members may be more populated, closer to courts or have more educated residents. These differences in council characteristics can affect whether citizens file complaints with the courts or the police. Therefore, a simple comparison between smaller and larger-sized councils would fail to recover the true causal effect.

To study this systematically, I leverage a design where a different number of council members assigned to “similar” areas. Particularly, I leverage the population-based cut-off that determines the number of council members in over 28,000 councils in Maharashtra, India using a regression discontinuity (RD) design. The RD design exploits the continuity in the running variable—that is, the population of the council and the discontinuity at the cutoff between being assigned a smaller or larger council size. As per the Maharashtra Village Panchayat Act of 1959, the number of council members is determined by population cut-offs which I tabulate in Table 1. Here, we see that at the first threshold, councils with a population greater than 1500 elect 9 members, while those with a population below the threshold elect 7 members. These treatments are assigned as per the populations in the 2011 census—consequently, I analyse councils that were created before 2011. For councils with populations close to the threshold, the treatment (addition of two council members) can be assumed to be as-if randomly assigned.

Table 1 shows that there are five cut-offs. This presents a choice to either normalize and pool the results to form a single cutoff, or estimate effects at each cutoff using a multi-cutoff regression discontinuity design (Cattaneo, Keele, et al. 2016). The multiple cut-offs can help overcome a common shortcoming of RD methods in estimating causal effects—with just a single cutoff, would not know if the treatment effect persists for those units whose scores on the running variable are farther away from the cut-off.

Before using these cutoffs, it is important to establish that they are not being used in other policies, as

Table 1: Council Population based cutoffs for number of members.

Council Population Thresholds	Number Of Council Members
<1500	7
1501-3000	9
3001-4500	11
4501-6000	13
6001-7500	15
>7501	17

Source: Maharashtra Village Panchayat Act, 1959. Population thresholds to be based strictly on previous census conducted.

population thresholds have been frequently used to determine eligibility for public programs (Asher and Novosad 2020) and electoral systems (Arora 2022). I systematically searched for government programs that would contaminate any of the five cutoffs shown in Table 1. While no such programs appear to use the 1500, 4500, 6000 and 7500 cutoffs, a cutoff of 3000 is being used to determine eligibility for three other government policies (details in Section B.1 and I exclude it from further analyses. Further, Table A3 shows that the 4500, 6000 and 7500 cutoffs not only change the size of the council, but also determines the number and size of wards within the council territory.

I thus analyse the first cutoff only: about 68% of councils in Maharashtra are exposed to the first cutoff, with populations between 750 and 2250. I leverage a sharp regression discontinuity design using council population. Data from council elections (Table A4) and an audit of villages (Table A5) shows that the rule is followed in practice.

I define causal effects in the potential outcomes setup as follows: $Y_i(0)$ and $Y_i(1)$ are the outcomes for council i , and X_i is the population of the council. The causal effect of an increase in council size by two members can be given as $Y_i(1) - Y_i(0)$. However, since both cannot be observed at the same time for individual councils, we can compute the average treatment effect exactly at the cutoff c as follows:

$$\tau = \mathbb{E}[Y_i(1) - Y_i(0)|X_i = c] = \mathbb{E}[Y_i(1)|X_i = c] - \mathbb{E}[Y_i(0)|X_i = c] \quad (1)$$

I collect outcomes for each village v that is nested within a council i , over seven years, with each year denoted by t .¹⁰ As the jurisdiction of each council can comprise of one or more villages, I modify the RD specification to accommodate the different levels and the temporal aspect of the data, and clustering the errors at the council level as follows:

$$Y_{vit} = \beta_0 + \tau \mathbf{1}(X_i \geq 0) + \beta_1 f_1(X_i) + \beta_2 f_2(X_i) \mathbf{1}(X_i \geq 0) + \epsilon_{vit} \quad (2)$$

Where Y_{vit} is the outcome for village v in council i in year t , ϵ_{vit} is the error term, $f(X_i)$ are two separate functions of the running variable. τ gives us the average treatment effect at the cutoff.

4.3 Key Assumptions of Identification

The key identification assumption in a regression continuity design is that the outcomes for the treated and untreated units are continuous in X_i around the threshold $X_i = c$ where X_i is the running variable and c denotes the cutoff. While the identification assumption is fundamentally untestable, we can increase the credibility of the regression discontinuity design using the following approaches.

Continuity in Running Variable: First, I conduct a density discontinuity test. This helps us assess whether there is any manipulation of the council population. Manipulation in this case would imply sorting by treatment: the concern is that a council can select into either side of the discontinuity through corruption, perhaps because smaller councils can help local elites secure their power by falsifying the population numbers. In such a scenario, the population distribution across villages will not be smooth.

We can assess whether there are distributional imbalances in the population numbers on either side of the cutoff. I run the test from Cattaneo, Jansson, and Ma (2020), using local polynomials ranging from the first to fourth order. The null hypothesis implies that there is no manipulation. For each order, the p-values are as follows: local linear (0.66), quadratic (0.49), cubic (0.42) and quartic

¹⁰Although I have data over time that could have allowed me to leverage a difference-in-discontinuities design, note that the treatment is assigned in the year of the census (2011) and the case-level data I collect is all from the period after the census is conducted and treatments are assigned. Thus, a difference-in-discontinuities is not applicable in this scenario.

Table 2: Larger and smaller councils are similar

Covariates	Units	Control	Treatment	<i>p-val</i>
All weather road	1/0	0.67	0.67	0.82
Public transport available	1/0	0.84	0.85	0.64
Internal road	1/0	0.37	0.36	0.63
Distance from HQ	km.	55.62	54.88	0.42
Graduates+	%	0.03	0.03	0.24
Distance to Court	km.	26.66	25.79	0.42
Distance to Police Station	km.	9.65	10.18	0.12
High income (INR 5000+)	%	22.90	23.01	0.82
High income (INR 10000+)	%	6.87	7.15	0.23

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. I take the means of observations within a bandwidth of 300 below and above the cutoff. The units column indicates the units of a measure: they can be either be for binary (roads, public transport availability) or continuous (distance, land, number of graduates, shares) variables. All variables are measured based on data from the 2011 Census or the 2011 Socio-Economic Caste Census, as compiled in the ‘SHRUG’ dataset. Distance to courts and police stations indicates the Haversine distance from the centroid of the council to the closest court or police station. ‘p-val’ indicates the p-value from two sided t-test.

(0.21). This implies that we have no evidence of manipulation, confirmed visually in Figure A4.

Continuity in Observable Characteristics: Second, influences on other council characteristics should be continuous in X at $X = c$. I test this by analyzing the means for larger and smaller council sizes in Table 2 below for a range of outcomes within a constant bandwidth. I first assemble a list of characteristics that could be possible confounds from the 2011 census—connectivity, geographical proximity to institutions and socio-economic characteristics of the council’s residents. Any imbalances on these may imply that the estimated treatment effects are due to other confounding factors, and not simply due to the increase in council size.

In Table 2, we see that the p-values for all possible pre-treatment confounders are greater than 0.05 thus we fail to reject the hypothesis that they are statistically distinguishable from each other. Further, I regress these on the treatment status of a council—I fail to reject the null hypothesis that the coefficients of the predictors are jointly 0, given a p-value of 0.49 associated with an F-statistic of 0.92. Figure A5 shows this graphically: connectivity (roads, availability of transport), geographic characteristics (distance to district headquarters, courts and police station) and socio-economic factors (education, income) are similar in councils in the treatment and control groups.

5 Results

In this section, I present two sets of results. First, I use analysis leveraging a sharp regression discontinuity design to show that increasing the size of the council increases access to the justice system, for both criminal and civil cases. Second, I present qualitative evidence that describes how council members serve as intermediaries.

5.1 Council members increase access to the justice system

I start by describing the patterns of the treatment and outcomes. Figure A1 shows the case filings are generally increasing over time. Figure A2 shows that about 68% of the councils are affected by the first cutoff—the focus of this analysis. Figure A3 shows the variation across the state where the outcomes could be measured: we see that the outcomes are well distributed across the state.

The main explanatory variable (treatment) takes the value 1 if the council population is at or greater than 1501, and 0 if it is not. Therefore, moving from control to treatment implies that the council will have two additional seats from which ward members are elected.¹¹ The results indicate the effects of a larger council on the number of cases filed from villages for all case types, criminal cases and civil cases between 2011 and 2023. The outcomes for each village are observed for each of the 12 years. I report local linear regression discontinuity estimates using the optimal bandwidth and triangular kernels based on Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014), with robust standard errors clustered at the council level in parentheses.

Table 3 shows the main results: each column indicates the total number of observations, the number of observations within the bandwidth, the estimated local average treatment effect τ and the robust bias-corrected p values. The first column shows that increasing the size of the elected body increases access to the justice system. The filing rate for villages in the control group is low: at 1.2 cases per year. Increasing the size of the council by two members leads to a 0.15 increase in the filing rate, corresponding to a 51% increase.

¹¹Each council, or *gram panchayat* is divided into geographical units called wards, and each ward elects two or three ward members. Table A3 shows that at the 1500 threshold, there are three wards in each council. Councils in the treatment group elect 3 members from each ward to elect a total of 9 members, while councils in the control group elect 3 members from one ward and 2 members from two wards, to elect a total of 7 members.

Table 3: Council Members Increase Access to the Justice System

	All Cases	Criminal Cases	Civil Cases
LATE	0.60** (0.27)	0.33* (0.19)	0.26** (0.11)
Observations	100038	100038	100038
Observations (bw)	27263	24543	36495
Bandwidth	187	169	250
Mean (control)	1.19	0.8	0.41
Effect (%)	51	41	64

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level. Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth. Each observation is a village-year.

The results remain consistent when I classify cases into criminal and civil cases. An increase in council size leads to a 41% increase in criminal case filings, and 64% for civil case filings. These results provide support H_1 —that increasing council size can increase access to the formal legal system.

Next, I test if additional council members affect court processes. While the previous section shows that the addition of two council members to the local body can increase case filings, I argue that they cannot meaningfully influence processes once the cases reach the courts. This is primarily due to two reasons: first, that the legal branch is sufficiently separated and insulated from the legislative branch, and second, that courts are extremely overburdened and slow due to a number of institutional reasons (Bhavnani, Bhogale, and Jadhav 2025) which hard to fix for individual cases, and to be influenced by council members.

I test this using the case level data, which allows me to calculate the number of decisions issued for each village, and if decided, the average time (in days) that the case was decided in, using the filing and decision dates for each case. We confirm these expectations in Table A11: the additional council members are not able to meaningfully influence court processes. Even though litigants from villages file a greater number of cases, courts do not issue a larger number of decisions, or resolve the cases quickly. This has two implications—first, the influence of council members is limited to making a bridge to the legal institutions possible, and second, that the working quality of the courts

does not diminish on account of being inundated by additional case filings.

An important question is whether these dynamics indicate legal assistance that is based on non-contingent constituency service, or assistance that is contingent on partisanship and electoral support (Bussell 2019). As members of village councils are not formally affiliated with political parties, I cannot directly test for partisan targeting. Another way to study the possibility of partisan assistance is to assess whether the composition of groups within a council determines *who* gets access to courts, however, since the composition of groups occurs after the treatment, such an assessment would induce post-treatment bias.

Nevertheless, I can study *patterns* of legal access that can point to the role of electoral incentives. I examine whether council members help with legal access mainly during election year, when they need electoral support. If members were employing discretion to provide assistance when it most benefits them, they would provide assistance as elections approach. Table A6 shows that the increase in legal access is heightened during the election year.

5.2 Robustness

In the Figures A6, A7 and A8, I show that these results are robust to varying the bandwidth, districts included in the sample and functional forms assumed. Further, Figure A9 shows no effects at placebo cutoffs. A concern with the analysis so far is that these results might change if we include cases filed from litigants in multiple villages. This would bias my result by overstating the benefits, since council members may not be equipped to serve as intermediaries for complex disputes that span litigants across different villages. In Tables A13 and A14, I show results from leveraging an alternate design using Regression Discontinuity Aggregation (RDA) (Borusyak and Kolerman-Shemer 2025). Here, I aggregate cases from multiple villages from the same sub-district, and estimate the effect of share of treated councils in the sub-district on case filings, instrumented by the proportion of treated councils close to the 1500 cutoff. The results remain consistent using this design: increasing the size of the council increases cases filed by 88%.

A second concern with these data is the possibility of missing cases: and particularly, if the missingness is associated with the treatment. I compute the possibility of missing cases using the

the serialized nature of the case numbers (Wu et al. 2026), which shows that at most, 26% of the overall data could be missing. This is a ceiling of missingness, as some courts may not be following the serialization rule. Nevertheless, I extend the RD analysis to focus on sub-districts with excellent data: where any possible missingness accounts for fewer than 10% of the observed cases. Table A15 displays results which remain consistent with the main finding.

Finally, I turn to different way to test of the theory by exploiting a natural experiment driven by the creation of 952 new councils between 2016 and 2022. These councils were formed by partitioning larger jurisdictions into smaller units. Based on the same population thresholds described in Table 1, these new council jurisdictions were assigned either a 7-member or 9-member council. To be sure, the split reduces the representation ratio across all new entities, the magnitude of this reduction much larger for the 9-member councils. Table A16 shows that larger councils increase the filing rate, however the results are not statistically significant. To further disentangle the effect, I implement a simple t-test comparing the filing rate of the council one year before and after the split, and find that the split increases the filing rate by 25% ($p = 0.04$).

5.3 Council Members Facilitate Access to the Justice System

I draw on qualitative data and shadowing to highlight the ways in which these council members facilitate access to the justice system. I use two sources of qualitative data. I analyze qualitative data from phone interviews with 19 council members currently serving in councils across Maharashtra. These informational interviews inquired about council members' role in addressing disputes in the village (see Section E.2 for the questionnaire). I provided them with two hypothetical scenarios of disputes: first, involving a family dispute involving land and inheritance, and second, an instance of a crime wherein a murder had been committed. A limitation of this question was that in many villages, crimes like murders are rare, and few members had experience with such a grave crime. Nonetheless, the question elicited responses regarding how they would deal with serious crimes in the village. I reproduce a number of quotes and excerpts that provide suggestive evidence of how council members act as intermediaries.

Most respondents agreed that most small disputes get resolved within the village itself and there is no requirement to involve external authorities. When prompted to elaborate on these differences,

one president said, “Typically, the *police patil*¹² and *sarpanch*¹³ will try to solve the dispute at the village level itself. Only in the case of a big crime, the police will get involved”. Another council member remarked: “If it is a major crime, it will go to the police station and the courts. Criminal cases cannot be resolved within the village”. This highlights the dual role that is played by council members: first they act as informal mediators, and second, they help litigants access the formal legal institutions.

Second, I asked council members about whether they know the police police, and to describe how they get to know them. One council member shared that he knows the *beat hawaldhar*.¹⁴ Another member shared: “If there is any issue in the village, or a case is registered from the village, the police will call the *gram panchayat* member, and we try to see if we can resolve the issue at the village level itself, since it will be a cheaper resolution”. A council president shared: “In case of any investigation in the village, the police get in touch with police patil, sarpanch and *gram panchayat* member”. These interviews highlight the forms of interactions and instances wherein police officers work with together with council members and request their help. This relationship allows council members to later reach out to them and request them to register complaints filed by citizens.

A major drawback of these informational interviews is that these are self-reported behaviors. I use a second source of qualitative data to demonstrate these direct interactions. I use data from anonymized field notes collected by research assistants from Bussell (2020b). Fourteen council presidents were ‘shadowed’ (Bussell 2020a) for approximately two days, as they carried out their regular daily activities. Bussell (2020a) explains: ‘this method allows for detailed descriptions of president’s behaviors and interactions’, and shares detailed notes on her website.

These notes demonstrate that council presidents exercise oversight of the police. Out of the fourteen presidents shadowed, 6 of them interacted with the police, where the council president requests the police to register complaints. I reproduce the evidence from the field notes during the shadowing of council president D: “Council president D was approached for help in filing an FIR for a

¹²The Maharashtra Gazette explains that the “police patil” is a village level official, subordinate to the Police Sub-Inspector of the area concerned. They are responsible for the maintenance of peace and order in the village, and is expected to assist the Police in investigating the crimes. Details reproduced from the Maharashtra Gazette at <http://bit.ly/409iuDb> accessed on July 10, 2025.

¹³The head of the elected council.

¹⁴The *beat hawaldhar* is the constables in-charge of the village, usually placed at the police headquarters.

stolen television set. The president calls the head constable, requesting to file an FIR”. During the shadowing of council president G, the notes share this instance: “Council president G was approached by a woman with whom the school headmaster had misbehaved, and the president helped the woman by helping her write an application to the senior police officer”. Finally, during the shadowing of council president J, we see a similar incident: “Council president J called the police officer in charge to investigate a case of a woman from the village who had been harassed by a man”. These instances highlight both that council presidents are approached for help to file police complaints, and that they intervene to do so by establishing direct contact with the police officers.

6 Supply-side and demand-side mechanisms

In this section I evaluate supply and demand-side mechanisms. I show that that additional members in a village council increases its capacity to help citizens with their problems. Further, I show that a larger council changes the *types* of representatives elected: a larger councils increases the number of members from diverse groups by increasing descriptive representation beyond mandated quotas. Finally, I test whether this changes demands from citizens: by looking at the profiles of litigants filing cases in larger councils. I find that a larger council changes the characteristics of litigants accessing the justice system—particularly, I find an increase in the filing rate by women and members belonging to the Scheduled Castes and Tribes.

6.1 Larger councils have greater capacity

Increasing the size of the council mechanically generates two changes: it decreases political jurisdictions and consequently, increases the representative to citizen ratio. This can make citizens feel closer to decision makers, making them more approachable and effective (Hansen [2015](#); Lassen and Serritzlew [2011](#)).

In the context of Maharashtra, the ratio of representative to citizens changes from 1:214 to 1:166: a decrease in the number of citizens per council member along with an increase in the ratio of council members to citizens (representative ratio) by 28%. Increasing the number of public officials in India—across bureaucracies (Muralidharan and Sundararaman [2013](#)) and judiciaries

(M. Rao 2024)—improves the performance of institutions in obtaining their goals. Increasing the representative ratio can increase assistance, given that local officials are overloaded with work (Dasgupta and Kapur 2020). Shirking and free-riding is not likely, given that local elections are frequent and competitive (Auerbach and Ziegfeld 2020).

I leverage survey data to test the observable implications of increasing the resources available for assistance, and show that a larger-sized council increases its capacity to solve local issues. I use data from the National Council of Applied Economics Rural Economic and Demographic Survey (REDS) to test this idea. This section analyzes the 2006-08 round of the nationally representative survey, which covers more than 8,000 rural households across India. I focus my analysis on more than 44,000 respondents from 233 villages in India, taking advantage of the fact that larger councils are allotted to villages between two elections, typically when they cross a population threshold.

The survey asks each respondent to rate the current and previous council members. Each respondent is asked to rate council members' honesty and qualifications, and rate how well council members solve social and local problems. Responses are based on an ordinal scale (High = 1, Medium = 2, Low = 3, Not aware = 4). I exclude respondents who answered they were not aware to answer about the quality and ability of council members, and recode the outcomes based on an increasing score of evaluation for ease of interpretation. Section E.1 describes the exact questions used in the survey.

I analyse the survey data with a difference-in-differences design, since ratings are collected for both the current and previous council. Of the 233 villages, 64 villages are assigned a larger council during the 2001 census, and the survey compares these evaluations for the current and previous period.

Thus, I can run a specification of the following:

$$Y_{it} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 \cdot \text{Post}_t + \beta_2 \cdot \text{Treat}_v + \beta_3 \cdot (\text{Post}_{it} \times \text{Treat}_v) + X_i + \epsilon_v \quad (3)$$

Here, Y_{it} represents the outcome for respondent i from village v at time t , Treat_v is an indicator that takes the value 1 if the respondent is in a treated village, Post_{it} takes the value 1 if the individual is evaluating the ratings for the current council, and 0 if the evaluation is for the previous council. X_i

includes respondent level controls: sex, religion, years of schooling and caste. Standard errors are clustered at the village level.

I find in Table 4 that on being assigned to a larger council causes respondents to increase their rating on a host of measures of quality and ability of council members—we see that the coefficients are positive for all outcomes, and statistically significant for two of them: respondents hold better perceptions of council member’s qualifications, wherein the treatment causes 3.6% increase in the outcome relative to baseline. Further, we see that respondents increase their evaluations of council member’s ability: the treatment causes a 3% increase in their perceptions of a council member’s ability to solve local problems relative to the baseline. An important caveat of this design is that responses have been collected at a single period, and respondent’s ratings of previous council members could be biased when they receive the treatment: that is, the bias in recall may differ between the treatment and control groups. As such, these results provide suggestive evidence of an increase in a larger council’s capacity to provide assistance.¹⁵

Table 4: Effect of Larger Council on Quality and Ability of Council Members

	Beneficiary Fairness	Qualifications	Solve social problems	Solve local problems
ATT	0.03 (0.03)	0.06* (0.03)	0.02 (0.03)	0.06** (0.03)
Observations	88,980	83,416	86,102	88,673
Adjusted R ²	0.01	0.01	0.01	0.01

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the village level. The treatment is council population crosses population threshold which assigns two additional seats. Each observation takes an ordinal outcome taking values between 1 and 3, with 3 being the highest rating. ‘Honesty’ is a rating of the council member’s honesty and fairness. ‘Qualifications’ is a rating of the council member’s technical qualifications. ‘Solve social problems’ is a rating of the council member’s ability to solve social problems, such as disputes over land, marriage etc. ‘Solve local problems’ is a rating of the council member’s ability to solve local problems such as roads, education, water etc.

6.2 Larger councils have greater descriptive representation

Another reason that could explain the increase in filing rate from villages with larger councils is that a larger council increases representation of non-dominant groups by affecting the electoral context:

¹⁵While it is possible to overcome these issues by looking at the *Socio Economic Profile of Rural Households in India (SEPRI) - 2014* survey, this was a shorter follow-up to the REDS and the same questions were not asked.

a larger number of seats would attract a larger number of candidates and in turn affect the turnout.

Representation of women, SC, ST and OBC council members is largely shaped by quotas. Political reservations in India stipulate 50% of seats to be reserved for women: consequently 50% of additional seats are also reserved for women. Quotas for SC, ST and OBC members are based on their respective shares in the council population. I test whether a larger council size increases descriptive representation beyond those mandated by the state. For each council, I calculate the representation of female, SC, ST and OBC council members who are not elected from a seat reserved for the respective groups. That is, for each council, I subtract the number of quota seats held by members of group g from the number of total seats held by members of group g .

I use the same sharp RD design to test whether the size of the council affects descriptive representation beyond that which is mandated by quotas. I use the data on the profiles of the council members—particularly data from the Maharashtra State Election Commission for elections held in 2021 that includes the gender and caste of all candidates.¹⁶ Of the 15003 election contests held in 2021, I correctly match the names of the council elections for 90% of councils to the 2011 Census that indicates population. 8055 of these are within the population range for the cutoff at 1500 which I analyse below.

In Table 5, we see that there are meaningful spillovers or ‘overflow’ of mandated quotas: increasing the size of the council increases the descriptive representation of female and SC members in the council, beyond those mandated by quotas.

What explains the increase in representation? While the theoretical underpinnings of a more representative council suggested that elections to larger councils might reduce the barriers to entry, Table A7 shows that this is not the case: for each seat in a larger council, I do not find any change in the competitiveness of the election or the number of candidates contesting for elections at each seat.

A second explanation is that quotas could be affecting descriptive representation beyond their target dimensions, due to different social norms. This follows from earlier work that finds that quotas for women changes the representation of non-dominant groups (members belonging to the SC, ST and OBC) (Karekurve-Ramachandra and Lee 2020), and quotas for non-dominant groups increases the

¹⁶This data was collected by Priyadarshi Amar during his dissertation fieldwork (Amar 2025) and I sincerely thank him for sharing the same.

descriptive representation of female council members (Amar 2025).

6.3 Larger councils increase demands

The supply-side mechanisms suggest that larger councils have greater capacity and descriptive representation—which can both change the number and types of citizens who are assisted with disputes. In this section, I evaluate demand-side mechanisms: that larger councils can increase the number of citizens making demands on the council, indicating greater political mobilization of citizens. I use the data on council elections to test whether a larger council increases election turnout. Table A8 shows that elections to a larger council increase the total number of contesting candidates by 19% and the overall turnout by over 21%, suggesting greater political mobilization in jurisdictions with a larger-sized council.

Table 5: Larger Councils increase representation beyond mandated quotas

	Additional Female Members	Additional SC Members	Additional ST Members	Additional OBC Members
LATE	0.17*** (0.06)	0.05* (0.03)	0.04 (0.03)	0.03 (0.09)
Observations	8055	8055	8055	8055
Observations (bw)	2984	2590	2247	2704
Bandwidth	258	223	194	234
Mean (control)	0.32	0.07	0.06	0.4
Effect (%)	53	74	61	8

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level. Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth. Each observation is a council that had elections in 2021.

Does the increase in representation and mobilization change the types of citizens making demands? I test this using the profiles of litigants involved in these cases. I classify the names mentioned in the case records by using a number of approaches.¹⁷ These approaches use a combination of methods—a neural network trained on name patterns relying on millions of names in the Indian

¹⁷In the Indian context, names have been used to reliably classify religion (Allie 2023; R. Chaturvedi and S. Chaturvedi 2024; Neggers 2018; Susewind 2015) and gender (Ash et al. 2025). The approach for classifying caste is not based on a prediction, but on actual population shares.

Electoral Rolls to predict gender (Laohaprapanon, Sood, and Chintalapati 2026), a simple statistical lookup of last names leveraging million of names in the Socio-Economic Caste Census of India to obtain population-level caste categories (Laohaprapanon and Sood 2026) and a neural network based classifier trained on names in the Bihar Land Records data to predict religion (Chintalapati, Dar, and Sood 2025). Details on how each case was classified are in Section A.7. Note that these names are of the litigants for civil cases, and of the defendants for criminal cases.

I use this information to test whether the increase in council size can change the characteristics of litigants accessing the justice system for civil cases. From Table 6, we see an increase in cases that have atleast one female litigant from councils with additional members. There is also a substantively large increase in the number of cases filed by litigants belonging to Scheduled Castes and Tribes.

Table 6: Increase in council size changes characteristics of litigants

	>=1 Female Litigant	>=1 Litigant from Non-Dominant Group	>=1 Litigant from Minority
LATE	0.12** (0.05)	0.08** (0.03)	0.02 (0.01)
Observations	100038	100038	100038
Observations (bw)	34952	32568	38532
Bandwidth	239	221	265
Mean (control)	0.19	0.1	0.01
Effect (%)	65	77	180

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level. Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth. Each observation is a village-year.

6.4 Alternate Explanations

The results shown so far paint an optimistic picture about the role played by council members who lower barriers to access the justice system. These findings could also underscore a more pessimistic story: one where council members persecute members from marginalized groups by filing criminal cases against them. I rule this out by using the same classification approaches to examine the demographic profile of defendants in criminal cases. If the increase in filings were

driven by state-led persecutions, we would find a disproportionate increase in criminal cases against marginalized groups. Table A12 confirms that there is no such increase in group-based persecution. This finding supports the theory and qualitative evidence presented so far that the increase in filings is on account of meaningful access for citizens.

Another mechanism that could drive increase in legal access is if council members can strengthen functions pertaining to the legal and law enforcement systems. They could petition action to implement village-level courts or increase staffing levels at the police station to increase monitoring and reporting. The former is not likely, given that the implementation of the panchayat-level courts, a part of the (*Gram Nyayalays*) program, remains a challenge: of the 5000 panchayat-level institutions proposed in 2008, only about 338 of these have been established as of 2026, with limited success (Bail 2015). To directly test whether additional council members decrease vacancies in the village police officer position, I use survey data from Alyssa R. Heinze, Brulé, and Chauchard (2025)—Table A9 shows that larger councils are not able to decrease vacancies of this position. Finally, a larger council could signal better state capacity and increase trust in state institutions (Hansen 2013). Descriptive analysis using citizen surveys from the IHDS-2011 suggest that the size of the council is not associated with confidence in the police and courts.

7 Conclusion

The United Nations identifies access to justice as a fundamental principle of the rule of law—without which people cannot exercise their rights, challenge discrimination or hold decision-makers accountable. This study asks whether elected officials can facilitate citizens’ access to the justice system, focusing on local governments in India. I provide three key pieces of evidence to support this idea. First, I show that increasing the size of the elected body—increasing the number of council members—increases access to the justice system, for both civil and criminal cases. I draw on qualitative data to highlight how these council members serve as facilitators: by exercising oversight and acting as intermediaries. The evidence suggests that these dynamics are driven by both supply-side and demand-side mechanisms. A larger sized council not only has greater capacity to serve citizens, but also increases descriptive representation beyond mandated quotas. This increase in descriptive representation is consequential: as demonstrated by greater filings by female litigants

and citizens belonging to the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes. Overall, council members play a key role in bridging citizens' access to the formal justice system. In doing so, this paper makes important contributions to the literature on access to justice and legal mobilization (Black 1973; Galanter 2010; Genn 1999; J. Krishnan et al. 2014; Sandefur 2008).

A major innovation of this study is to answer this question using a credible regression discontinuity design, interviews and micro-level data on court cases. A natural limitation of this setting is that I only study the disputes that reach the formal justice system. The outcomes studied in this paper show that rather than substituting for a weak formal legal system, elected officials play a complementary role, channeling cases towards the courts. However, council members could also substitute the courts, by mediating and resolving disputes even before they reach the courts, an important question for future work.

Governments in developing countries began a process of decentralization in the 1970s, to increase responsiveness and improve local development (Bardhan 2002). A key aspect of the decentralization process has been the formation smaller political units that elect a number of local representatives, creating local bodies for urban and rural areas. Such local bodies are not unique to India, and span countries across the world like Indonesia, Brazil, Uganda, China, South Africa, Pakistan and Bolivia (Bardhan and Mookherjee 2006). By demonstrating how members of these local bodies facilitate access to justice, this study contributes to the larger comparative literature on local politics and decentralization. More research is needed to study how these local bodies affect services for citizens.

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Appendix: The Political Roots of Legal Access: Evidence from Village Councils in India

A	Data Description	43
A.1	Trends over Time	43
A.2	Distribution of Council Populations	43
A.3	Spatial Distribution	44
A.4	Variable Sources	45
A.5	Outcomes	46
A.6	Subordinate Courts	48
A.7	Classifying Litigant Names	49
B	Treatment Details	49
B.1	Multiple Treatments at 3000	49
B.2	Treatment Dose	50
B.3	Regression Discontinuity Assumptions: No Sorting	51
B.4	Regression Discontinuity Assumptions: Continuity	52
B.5	Test for Compliance	54
C	Other Explanations	55
C.1	Election Cycle Effects	55
C.2	Electoral Context and Mobilization	55
C.3	Council size does not affect police-related functions	57
C.4	Council size is not associated with trust in institutions	58
C.5	Council size does not affect case resolution	58
C.6	Council size does not increase identity-based persecutions	60
D	Sensitivity Analysis	60
D.1	Sensitivity to Bandwidth Choice	60
D.2	Sensitivity to District Characteristics	61
D.3	Sensitivity to Functional Form	62

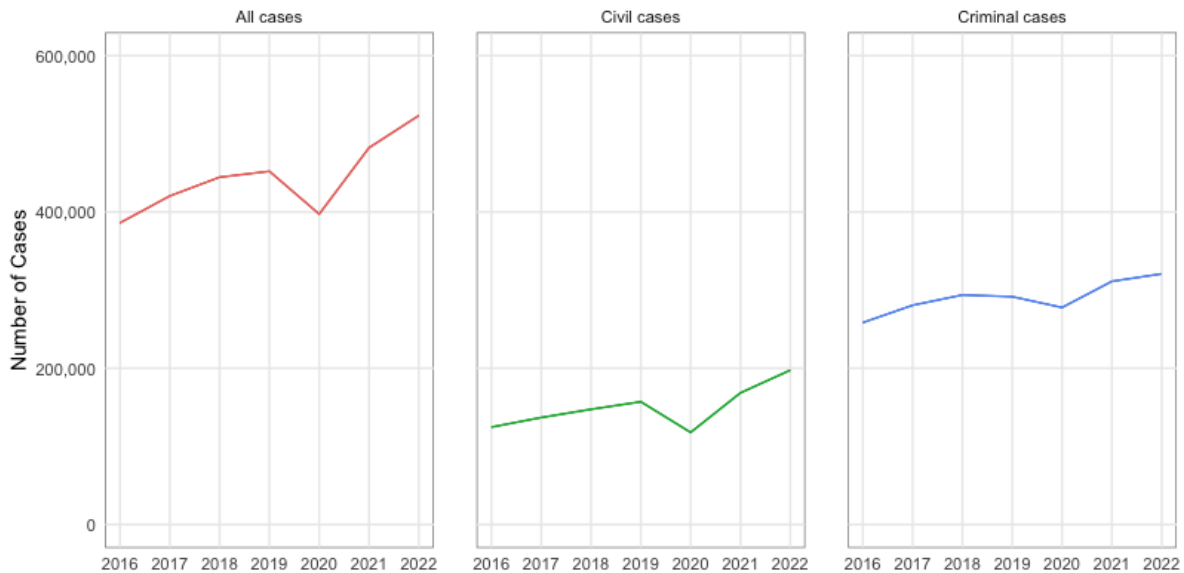
D.4	Results at placebo cut-offs	62
D.5	Robustness using Regression Discontinuity Aggregation	63
D.6	Robustness subsetting to low-missingness sub-districts	66
D.7	Natural experiment: Newly formed councils	68
E	Additional details	69
E.1	Rural Economic and Demographic Survey Questions Used	69
E.2	Interview Questionnaire	70

A Data Description

A.1 Trends over Time

In this section, I show some descriptive figures. Figure A1 plots the trend of the main outcome (case filings) over the years for each case type: all, criminal and civil cases.

Figure A1: Cases trend over time

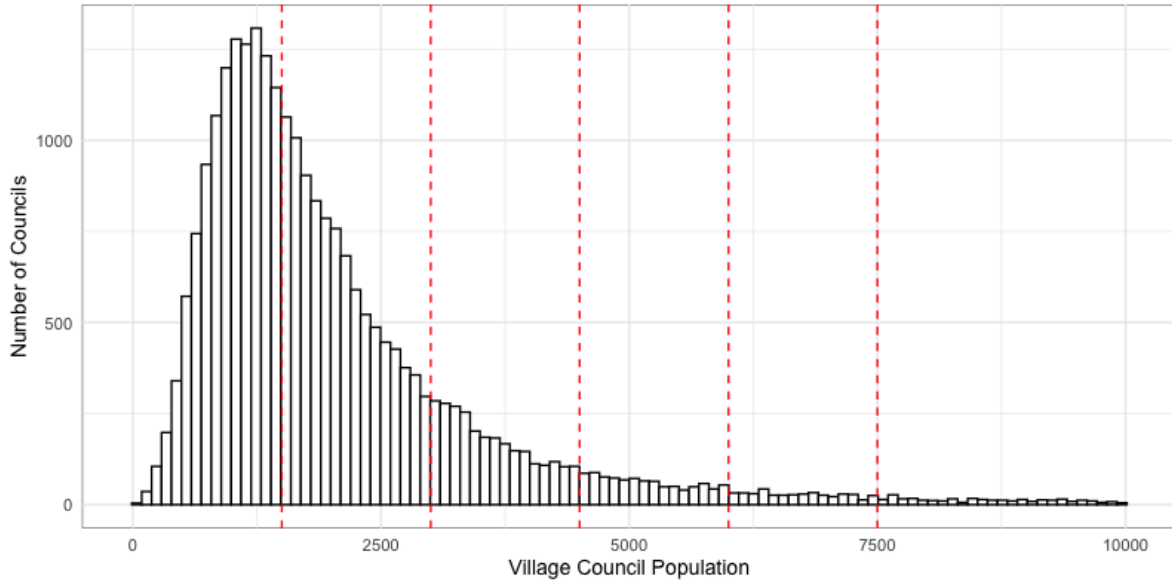


Note: The above plot shows the trend of the total number of cases in each year by category. The dip in 2020 is on account of the COVID-19 pandemic.

A.2 Distribution of Council Populations

Figure A2 shows a histogram of council populations. Here we observe that the majority of the council data is around the 1500 cutoff, and the share of councils at each cutoff decreases at each subsequent cutoff.

Figure A2: Council Population Distribution

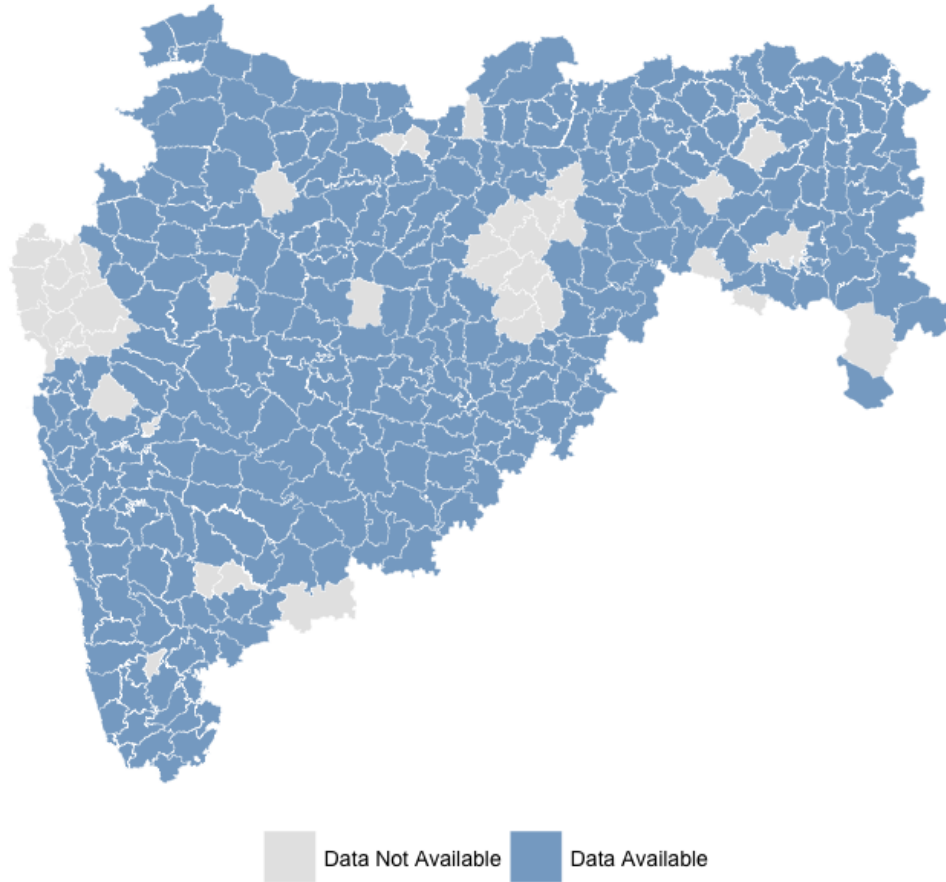


Note: Dotted red lines indicate population-based cutoffs that add two additional council members. Data representing 25,602 councils that could be mapped to their populations using administrative datasets. Figures excludes 1.2% of councils with populations greater than 10,000.

A.3 Spatial Distribution

To provide an overview of the data dispersion, Figure A3 plots the data availability at the sub-district level that has been analysed in the paper. In this map, I plot the sub-districts, indicating the sub-districts where the case-level data could be collected. The figure shows that the councils within the sub-districts analyzed in the main analysis are well distributed across the state. Note that the outcome data was not available for the entire districts of Hingoli, Washim, Thane and Palghar, in addition to some sub-districts. 6 sub-districts were excluded due to non-availability of data, and 11 sub-districts were excluded since the courts were created between 2016 and 2022.

Figure A3: Maharashtra Sub-District Maps: Availability of Case Data



Note: Sub-districts shaded in blue are the those for which case data from courts is available. We see from this figure that these are well-distributed across the state.

A.4 Variable Sources

The primary data used in the paper comes from a number of Indian public agencies. Further information is given in Table [A1](#).

Table A1: Data Sources

Name	Source Description	Data Provided	URL / Source
eCourts	Maharashtra District Courts	Village-level case data	https://court.mah.nic.in/courtweb/index_eng.php
LGD	Local Government Directory	Council-Village mapping	https://lgdirectory.gov.in/
shrug	Census of India 2011	Population data, council characteristics	https://www.devdatalab.org/shrug
Elections	Maharashtra State Election Commission	Elections data	Scraped from https://mahasec.maharashtra.gov.in/ , Data on quotas collected during fieldwork by Priyadarshi Amar
REDS 2006	Rural Economic and Demographic Survey 2006	Survey data	Data provided by Andrew Foster
IHDS 2011	Indian Human Development Survey 2011	Survey data	https://ihds.umd.edu/

A.5 Outcomes

- Number of all cases 2016-2022: Number of all cases filed in lower courts in the district courts at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class for each village.
- Number of criminal cases 2016-2022: Number of criminal cases (as decided by coding rule given below) filed in lower courts in the district courts at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class for each village, as determined by case classification rule in Table A2
- Number of civil cases 2016-2022: Number of civil cases (as decided by coding rule given below) filed in lower courts in the district courts at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class for each village, as determined by case classification rule in Table A2
- Number of violence against women cases 2016-2022: Number of violence against women

cases (as determined by case classification rule in Jassal (2024)) filed in lower courts in the district courts at the level of Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division or Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class for each village.

Table A2: Rules to classify cases as civil or criminal

Case Type	Classification	Detailed Reason
R.C.S.	Civil	Regular civil suit
Civil M.A.	Civil	
M.A.C.P.	Civil	Motor accident claims
Reg Dkst	Civil	Civil court judgement
Arbitration R.D	Civil	Arbitration only for civil
Marriage Petn.	Civil	
L.A.R.	Civil	Land acquisition reference
R.C.A.	Civil	Regular civil appeal
Spl.C.S.	Civil	Special civil suit
PWDVA Appln.	Civil	Domestic violence
M.C.A.	Civil	Misc civil appeal
Spl .Dkst	Civil	Civil court judgement
MACP. Dkst.	Civil	Motor accident claims
M.J.Cases	Civil	Misc judicial cases
MACP. M.A.	Civil	Motor accident petition
Succession	Civil	Succession post deceased
Darkhast	Civil	
L.R.DKST.	Civil	
Sum.Civ.Suit	Civil	
Civil Suit	Civil	
Civil Revn.	Civil	
Civil Appeal PPE	Civil	
S.C.C.	Criminal	Summary criminal case
R.C.C.	Criminal	Regular criminal case
Cri.M.A.	Criminal	
Cri.Bail Appln.	Criminal	Bail application
Other Misc.Cri.Appln	Criminal	
Sessions Case	Criminal	Sessions court
Cri.Rev.App.	Criminal	Criminal revision application
Cri.Appeal	Criminal	Criminal appeal
Cri.Case	Criminal	
Spl Case MSEB	Criminal	MSEB theft of electricity
Cri.Municipal Appeal	Criminal	
Juvenile Cri.MA	Criminal	

A.6 Subordinate Courts

The data spans the universe of cases in the subordinate courts of Maharashtra. On the civil side, the creation of courts follows from rules as per the Maharashtra Civil Courts Act¹⁸. The State Government has the power to create District Courts, and the presiding judge in the district is called the “District Judge”. Further, in each district, a number of “subordinate civil courts” can be created by the state government which are subordinate to the District Court: the focus of this paper. The District Court has appellate jurisdiction from decrees and orders of the subordinate courts. The judges practicing in these subordinate courts are called “Civil Judges”, and the location of such courts and local limits of the jurisdiction are determined by notifications in the Official Gazette.

On the criminal side, creation of courts follows from the Code of Criminal Procedure, Maharashtra.¹⁹ The State Government establishes a Court of Sessions headed by the Chief Judicial Magistrate for every district. Further, the state government establishes courts of Judicial Magistrates (First and Second Class) at the sub-district level: the focus of this paper.

The data concerns cases in the subordinate courts that are located at the sub-district level—these include courts of the Civil Judge Junior Division, Civil Judge Senior Division and Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class described above. Focusing on these two categories of judges makes sure that the dynamics concern similar civil and minor to moderate criminal cases. The exact pecuniary and punishment limits of the courts are given below:

- (i) Civil Judge Junior Division: judges hear cases that do not exceed a pecuniary value of 500,000 INR (~ \$6000)
- (ii) Civil Judge Senior Division: judges hear cases that do not exceed a pecuniary value of 1,00,000 INR (~ \$10,000)
- (iii) Judicial Magistrate First/Second Class: judges hear cases that involve imprisonment of less than three years or fines not exceeding 10,000 INR (~ \$100)

¹⁸Link to Maharashtra Civil Courts Act: <https://bit.ly/mh-civil-rules>

¹⁹Link to Code of Criminal Procedure, Maharashtra: <https://bit.ly/mh-crim>

A.7 Classifying Litigant Names

I use three approaches to classify names of litigants. First, a neural network trained on name patterns relying on millions of names in the Indian Electoral Rolls is used to predict gender (Laohaprapanon, Sood, and Chintalapati 2026). Particularly, the method relies on a Convolutional Neural Network that can detect patterns and phonetic endings to classify names. The model predicts the probability that a name is female. I classify a case as having at least one female litigant, if the probability of any of the litigants name being female is greater than 0.8.

Second, a deterministic table look up is created from the Socio-Economic Caste Census of India to obtain population-level caste categories (Laohaprapanon and Sood 2026). For example, if a name is assigned a value of 0.2 for a group, it means that 20% of the people with the surname in 2011 belonged to the group. I classify a litigant's surname as belonging to the Scheduled Caste or Scheduled Tribe using the following rule. The true shares of members belonging to the Scheduled Tribes and Scheduled Castes is 10% and 12%, any surname where the proportion is over 20% or 24% respectively (twice the base rate) is classified as belonging to the group. Thus, I classify a case as having at least one litigant belonging to the Scheduled Castes or Scheduled Tribe, if the proportion of surnames belonging to the group is greater than 24% and 20% respectively.

Third, a neural network based classifier trained on names in the Bihar Land Records data is used to classify religion (Chintalapati, Dar, and Sood 2025). It returns a probability that a name has patterns associated with Muslim names, with an out of sample accuracy of 98%. Each word in a name is mapped to a vector space, and the representation is passed onto a classifier. I classify a litigant name as Muslim if the confidence score is greater than 70. Consequently, I classify a case as having at least one Muslim litigant, if the confidence score for any name is greater than 70.

B Treatment Details

B.1 Multiple Treatments at 3000

I searched for government programs that would contaminate any of the five cutoffs. While no such programs appear to use the 1500, 4500, 6000 and 7500 cutoffs, a cutoff of 3000 is being used to

determine eligibility for a number of schemes:

- (1) A nationwide development program launched in 2014 called *Saansad Adarsh Gram Yojana*²⁰, wherein each member of parliament can choose a group of villages in their constituency to implement developmental programs.
- (2) The Government of Maharashtra using the 3000 threshold to determine additional staffing for the village panchayats²¹
- (3) The prize money for the “Tanta Mukti Scheme” (dispute-free villages) increases by 33% at the 3000 population cutoff²²

B.2 Treatment Dose

The main results in the paper looks at treatment effects using the first cutoff. It is important to note that a number of factors change at each cutoff, most important being other policies in place and design and size of the wards. These differences are summarized in Table A3. There are other policies in place at 500 and 3000 cutoffs. The 4500 and 7500 cutoffs add a new ward for the additional council members. The 6000 cutoff has more than double the ward size as compared to the first cutoff, as seen in column 4 in Table A3.

²⁰Source: <https://bit.ly/sansad-agy>, Last Accessed: 10 July, 2025, Page archived locally.

²¹Source: <https://bit.ly/gp-staffing>, Last Accessed: 10 July, 2025, Page archived locally.

²²Source: <https://bit.ly/tantamuktischeme>, Last Accessed: 10 July, 2025, Page archived locally.

Table A3: Heterogeneity in Ward Size and Design

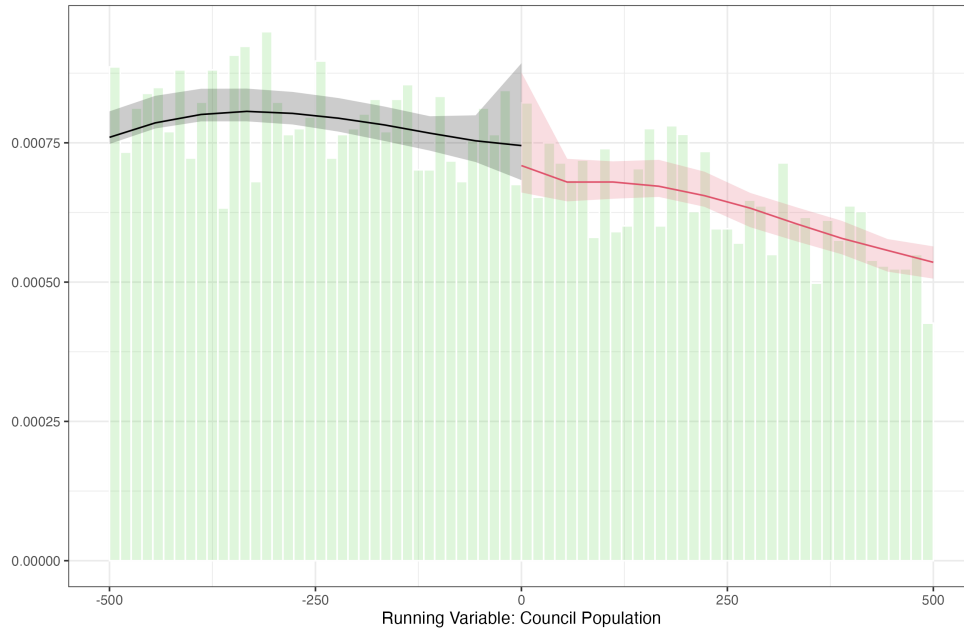
Threshold	Council Growth	Ward Design	Ward Size (appx)
500	—	Roads construction policy	NA
1500	7 → 9 (28% ↑)	3,2,2 → 3,3,3	500 (No change)
3000	9 → 11 (22% ↑)	3,3,3 → 3,3,3,2	1000 → 750
4500	11 → 13 (18% ↑)	3,3,3,2 → 3,3,3,2,2	1125 → 900
6000	13 → 15 (15% ↑)	3,3,3,2,2 → 3,3,3,3,3	1200 (No change)
7500	15 → 17 (13% ↑)	3,3,3,3,3 → 3,3,3,3,3,2	1500 → 1250

Notes: Threshold indicates population-based cutoffs. Details provide the policy in place, along with the increase in council size in brackets. Ward design indicates the number of candidates and the total number of wards. For example, 3,2,2 indicates 3 wards with the first, second and third ward electing 3, 2 and 2 members respectively. Ward size shows how the number of persons changes in each ward at the threshold; at the 1500 and 6000 threshold there is no change in ward size since the number of wards remain the same.

B.3 Regression Discontinuity Assumptions: No Sorting

The RDD is based on the assumption is that there is no manipulation (indicative of sorting) of the forcing variable (in this case, council population) near the cutoff. This would be the case if influential persons in a village were able to falsify the population numbers to allocate either fewer or greater number of members than prescribed by the design. Given that the enumerators are typically government school teachers or local officials, it might be possible for local elites to influence the enumeration process, and report lower or higher numbers if they perceive that certain benefits would be received. Another way this might happen is if people migrate to villages with either larger or smaller council sizes such that they are governed by their desired number of council members. While both these processes seem unlikely, I plot the density of the running variable and conduct a formal test from Cattaneo, Jansson, and Ma (2020) in Figure A4. The local polynomial of degree 2 are constructed using a triangular kernel function, with jackknife standard errors.

Figure A4: Density Discontinuity Test



Notes: The plot in the figure shows the density of council population based on the 2011 census around the 1500 cutoff. Figures and tests provide evidence for the absence of discontinuities at the thresholds.

B.4 Regression Discontinuity Assumptions: Continuity

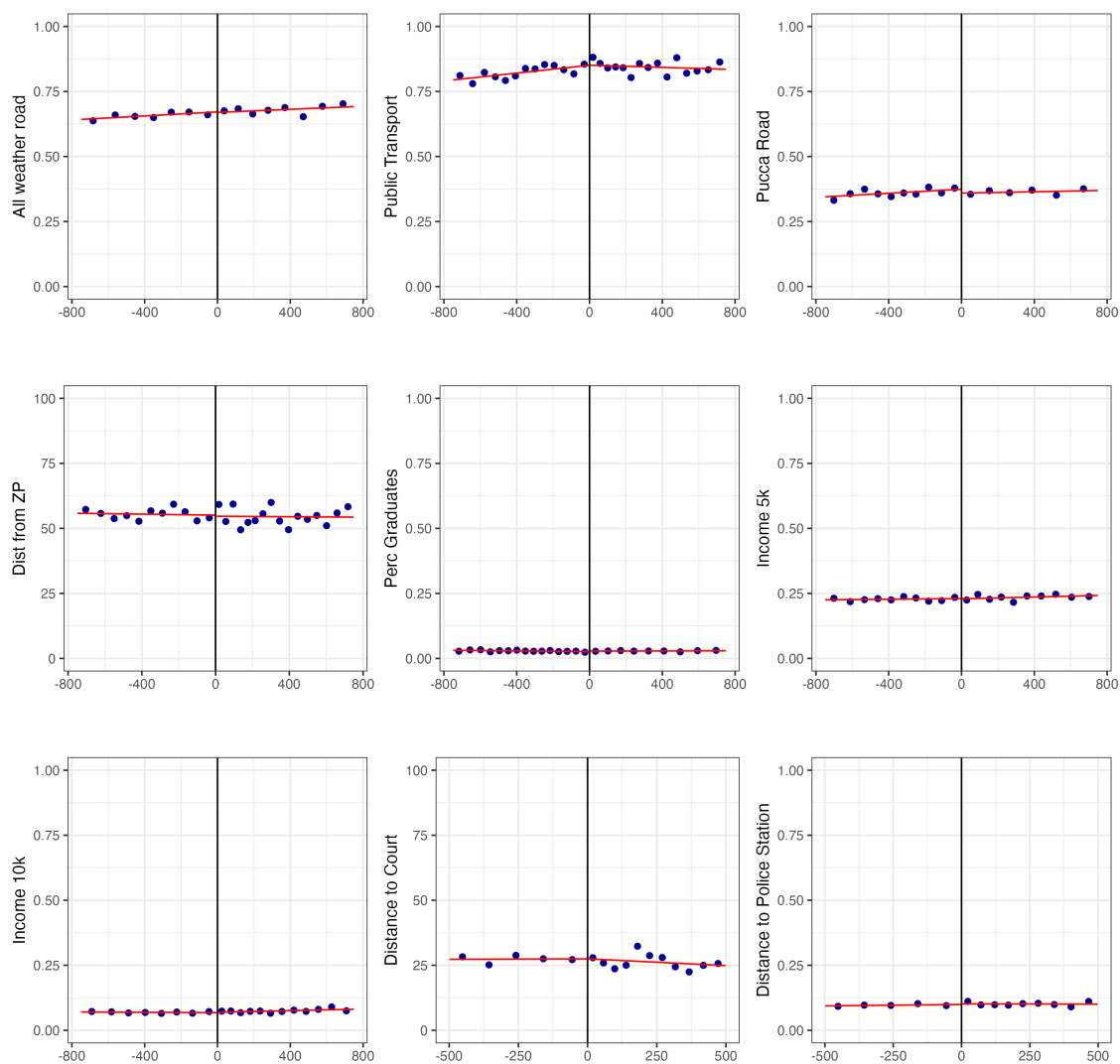
The second key identification assumption of the regression discontinuity design is that pre-treatment covariates are balanced around the population threshold. The lack of balance might imply confounding—the estimates of the treatment may be biased.

I test this assumption by collecting data from a number of data sources, particularly focusing on factors that are most likely to lead to confounding in this set-up: connectivity (availability of roads, transport and distance to headquarters), area (in square meters) governed by the council, number of graduates and high income earners. While the main paper discusses the differences between the treatment and control groups near the threshold, I visualize the data using plots here in Figure A5

Visually, it appears that a larger council is further away from the *Zilla Parishad* (ZP) that indicates the district capital, and has a greater number of graduates. On the other hand, smaller councils have a smaller share of high-income earners. Finally, in larger councils, while there appears to be a greater probability of having access to public transport, there is also a lower probability of having

an all weather or internal road. There does not appear to be any conclusive evidence on the presence of large discontinuities in pre-treatment covariates.

Figure A5: Covariate Balance



Notes: Each blue dot in the figure represents an outcome (indicated on the y-axis) for each council, based on quantile-spaced binning. Red lines denote local linear regressions. Data for the first five outcomes comes from the 2011 census, data on incomes comes from the Socio-Economic and Caste Census 2012, and data on distances (to courts and police station) computed by author.

B.5 Test for Compliance

I show compliance with the rule at each of the cutoffs. I use the data on council elections between 2017 and 2022 and focus on the winners. I produce the regression discontinuity estimates on the number of ward members at each cutoff in Table A4. While we would expect that these estimates are precisely 2, they will not be perfect on account of two reasons. First, ward member elections include election for the council head (sarpanch) for some years when the council head was to be indirectly elected, and exclude the council head for other the years when the council head was to be directly elected. Second, seats where no candidates contested are not counted here. As such, all results in the paper be interpreted as intent-to-treat estimates.

Table A4: Ward members' election data shows high compliance

	Pooled	1500	3000	4500	6000	7500
LATE	1.23*** (0.15)	1.13*** (0.17)	1.82*** (0.36)	2.29** (0.99)	0.27 (1.46)	2.63 (1.63)
Observations	22531	15308	4503	1318	570	832
Observations (bw)	8542	4484	1082	286	185	356
Bandwidth	307	229	197	177	243	1045
Mean (control)	6.47	5.79	7.17	9.07	10.4	11.82
Effect (%)	19	20	25	25	3	22

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level. Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth.

I use an alternate approach to show that the treatment leads to an increase in council size, leveraging an audit design from the 320 villages surveyed in A. Heinze (2025). From this dataset, I analyze 220 villages that are affected by the first cutoff. I find that assignment to treatment increases the number of council members by almost two members.

Table A5: Compliance from Survey of Village Councils

	Total Members
LATE	1.96** (0.84)
Observations	172
Observations (bw)	66
Bandwidth	279
Mean (control)	6
Effect (%)	33

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level.

Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth. Each observation is a gram panchayat.

C Other Explanations

C.1 Election Cycle Effects

In this section, I test whether the treatment effect of the RD is distributed across the electoral cycle. I identify election timing using dates of tenures held by council members using the *MahaEgram* data for each council. I restrict the data to years during and after 2018, the earliest date for which I can cleanly identify the councils' election timing, and indicate the number of years each council is away from the next election. Table A6 shows that the treatment effect strongest during the election year.

C.2 Electoral Context and Mobilization

One reason why members of larger councils are more effective in facilitating access to justice could relate to the electoral context. Elections to seats in larger councils could be more competitive, and the elected officials respond to the increase in electoral competition by lodging fake cases against rivals, or by being more engaged in their constituency and increase legal access for citizens.

To test this idea, I collect data on council elections between 2017 and 2022, focusing on the election of ward members. There were 162,947 seat level contests, of which I merge 85% of contests with the census data, arriving at at 72,036 seat-level contests I analyse at the 1500 cutoff in Table A7. I use the seat-level data to create three outcomes for each seat: (1) whether the seat had a close

Table A6: Results by election year for all cases

	Election Year	1 year pre	2 years pre	3 years pre	4 years pre
LATE	1.39*** (0.52)	0.14 (0.36)	0.52 (0.35)	0.34 (0.41)	0.26 (0.49)
Observations	8331	11881	12315	7011	9899
Observations (bw)	1543	3039	3575	2522	2972
Bandwidth	127	177	199	255	208
Mean (control)	1.42	1.38	1.26	1.08	1.39
Effect (%)	98	10	41	31	19

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level.

Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth. Each observation is a village-year.

election between the top two contenders, that is, the margin of victory was less than 10%; and (2) the number of candidates who contested for each seat. Table A7 shows that elections to seats in larger councils are not more competitive: seats are similar in terms of the number of contesting candidates and whether the contest was decided by a close election.

The presence of additional seats in larger councils should lead to an overall increase in number of contesting candidates at the council level. These additional contestants could increase political activity and increase the turnout, which could shape the types of assistance provided by council members once elected, and the types of citizens to whom assistance is provided. This channel only makes sense if the increase in turnout is meaningful in shaping who wins.

I test this by aggregating elections data at the council level in Table A8. There were 22,816 council elections during this period, of which I merge 86% of councils with the census data, arriving at 11,707 council-level contests I analyse at the 1500 cutoff. I use the council-level data to create three outcomes: (1) the total number of contesting candidates; (2) the overall turnout (3) the share of votes which support “None-of-the-Above” or NOTA votes, that are used by voters to signal lower legitimacy and support. Table A8 shows that a larger council increases the total number of contesting candidates by 18%, and the turnout by 21%, and has no effect on the share of NOTA votes cast by voters. Taken together, these results further support the supply and demand-side mechanisms

argued in the paper.

Table A7: Larger councils and electoral context: by seat

	Candidates per Seat	Close Elections
LATE	-0.03 (0.04)	-0.004 (0.02)
Observations	72036	72036
Observations (bw)	25293	27741
Bandwidth	234	257
Mean (control)	2.29	0.36
Effect (%)	-1	-1

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level. Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth.

Table A8: Larger councils and electoral context: by council

	Total Candidates	Turnout	NOTA (share)
LATE	2.35*** (0.37)	401.74*** (66.54)	0.002 (0.002)
Observations	11707	11707	11707
Observations (bw)	5111	4853	3423
Bandwidth	298	281	199
Mean (control)	13.05	1898.56	0.02
Effect (%)	18	21	10

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level. Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth.

C.3 Council size does not affect police-related functions

One alternate explanation for the increased criminal cases is that additional council members are able to strengthen other functions pertaining to the police. For example, adding council capacity might increase their effectiveness in recruiting a village police officer (known as a police patil). I use the same data of 220 villages for which a survey was conducted in Maharashtra (A. Heinze 2025;

A. R. Heinze, Brulé, and Chauchard 2025), and in Table A9 I show that assignment to treatment has no statistically significant effect on whether a police patil is recruited.

Table A9: Does village have a police patil?

	0=Yes / 1 = No
LATE	−0.05 (0.35)
Observations	167
Observations (bw)	50
Bandwidth	232
Mean (control)	0.79
Effect (%)	−7

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level.

Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth. Each observation is a gram panchayat.

C.4 Council size is not associated with trust in institutions

An alternate explanation that explains the increase in citizens accessing courts is that increasing council size increases trust in institutions. I show that this is not the case, using descriptive analysis that uses data from the *Indian Human Development Survey-II* in Table A10.

Each respondent is a head of the household. ‘Confidence in Police’ and ‘Confidence in Courts’ are outcomes that take the value 1 if the respondent selects “a great deal of confidence”, as opposed to “only some” or “hardly any confidence”. ‘Panchayat member close to household’ takes value 1 if a panchayat member or official is within or close to the household. The results indicate that while respondents in larger councils report that they have access to a council member close to their household, a larger number of members is not associated with greater confidence in the police or courts.

C.5 Council size does not affect case resolution

Decision information is determined using cases upto 2018 present in the data shared by Ash et al. (2025). Results in Table A11.

Table A10: Effect of Council Size on Trust in Institutions

	Panchayat member close to household	Confidence in Police	Confidence in Courts
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Number of Council Members	0.007** (0.003)	−0.0001 (0.002)	−0.0004 (0.001)
State FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Religion FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Caste Category FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Observations	15,407	15,407	15,407
R ²	0.180	0.056	0.051

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the village level. The independent variable is the reported number of council members.

Table A11: Politicians do not affect court processes

	Decisions	Time to Decision
LATE	0.12 (0.10)	−6.58 (26.61)
Obs. (L)	88568	8390
Obs. (R)	48624	5810
Effective Obs. (L)	30456	3349
Effective Obs. (R)	25576	3120
Bandwidth	309	329
Bandwidth (Bias)	524	497

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Robust standard errors in paranthesis clustered at the council level. The treatment is councils with two additional members. Each observation is number of decisions and the mean time to decision for cases measured from a village in a particular year. Obs. (L) and Obs. (R) indicate the number (and effective number) of observations to the left and right of the cutoff respectively. Bandwidth is in number of persons. Note that the fewer number of observations for the time to decision outcome is due to the fact that it can only be measured if a decision is issued for a case filed from the council in a particular year.

C.6 Council size does not increase identity-based persecutions

Results in Table A12.

Table A12: Increase in council size does not lead to identity-based persecutions

	>=1 Female Accused	>=1 Accused from Non-Dominant Group	>=1 Accused from Minority
LATE	0.03 (0.03)	0.08 (0.06)	0.01 (0.01)
Observations	100038	100038	100038
Observations (bw)	33338	27773	26263
Bandwidth	226	191	181
Mean (control)	0.11	0.22	0.02
Effect (%)	30	37	68

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level. Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth. Each observation is a village-year.

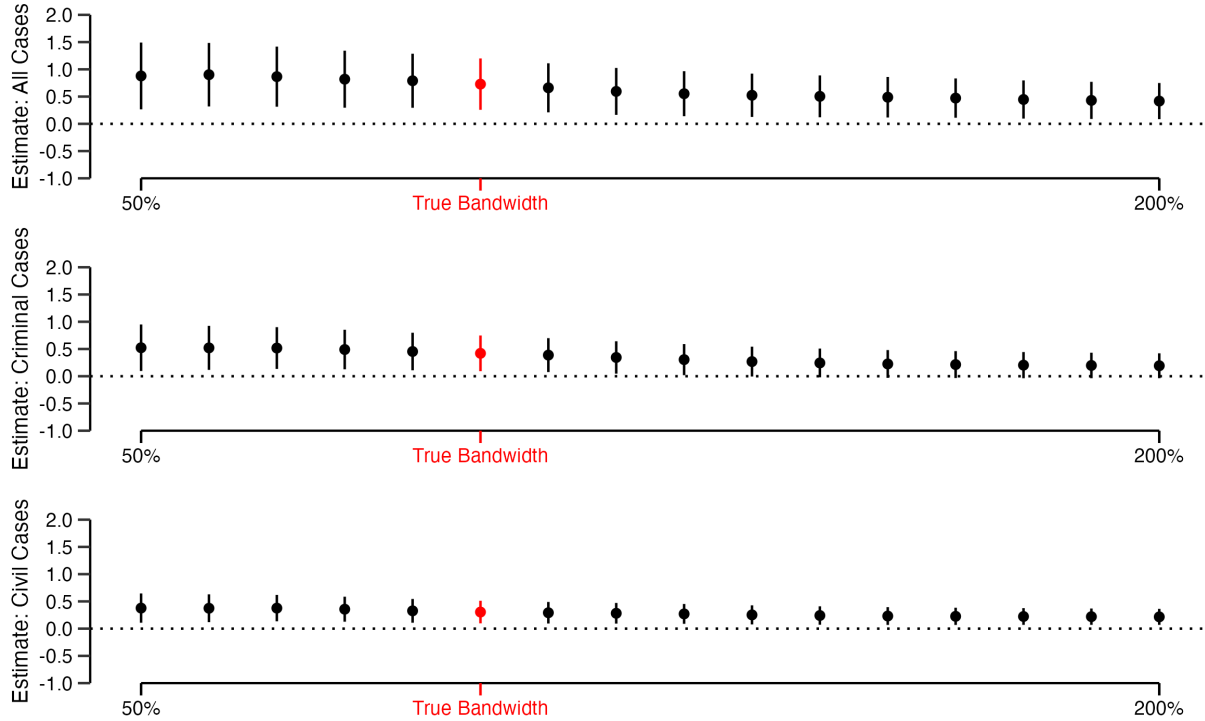
D Sensitivity Analysis

D.1 Sensitivity to Bandwidth Choice

In this section, I present sensitivity tests for bandwidth selection. I follow the suggestions of Bueno and Tunon (2015)²³ and vary bandwidth from 50% to 200% of the Calonico, Cattaneo, and Titiunik (2014) estimate in Figure A6. We see that our results are not sensitive to the choice of bandwidth.

²³Graphical Presentation of Regression Discontinuity Results, The Society for Political Methodology Blog. Available at: <https://bit.ly/rd-link>

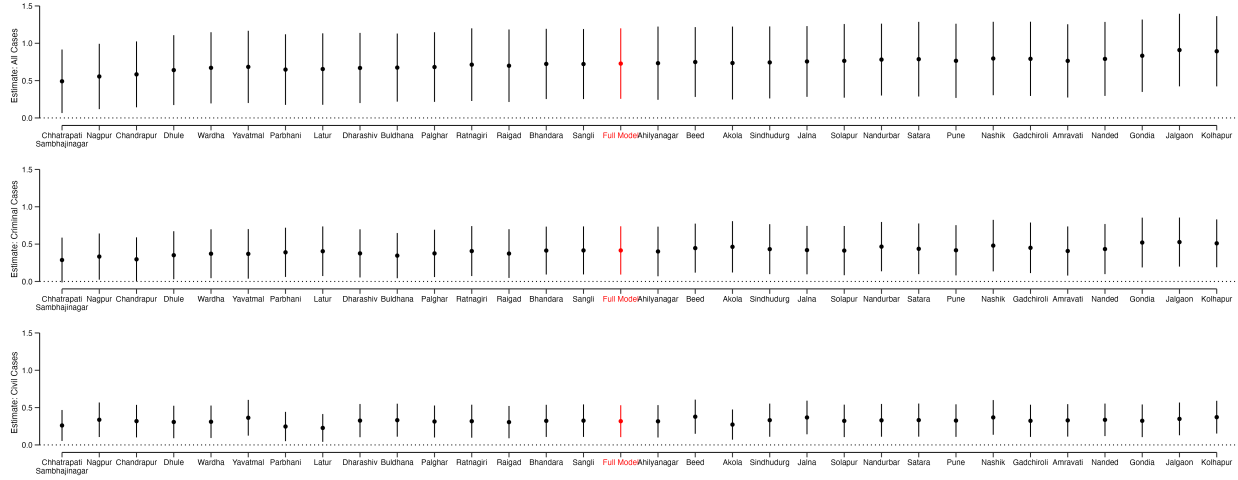
Figure A6: Results not sensitive choice of bandwidth



D.2 Sensitivity to District Characteristics

Due to the large size of the state, Maharashtra has a lot of geographic variation. For instance, some districts could be more geographically compact that allows individuals to access courts easily as compared to districts that are more geographically spread out. A concern of this is that the results could be driven by the inclusion of an outlier district that skews the average. I run the analysis by dropping one district at a time to investigate if the results are sensitive to the presence of such a district. The results in Figure A7 show that the estimates remain robust.

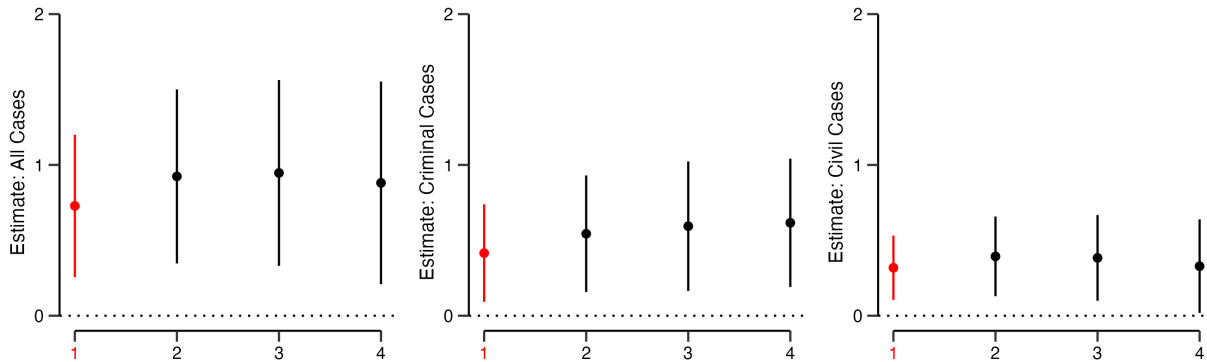
Figure A7: Sensitivity to District Characteristics



D.3 Sensitivity to Functional Form

In Figure A8, I show that the results remain robust to changing the functional form: using linear ($p=1$), quadratic ($p=2$), cubic ($p=3$) and quartic ($p=4$).

Figure A8: Sensitivity to Functional Form

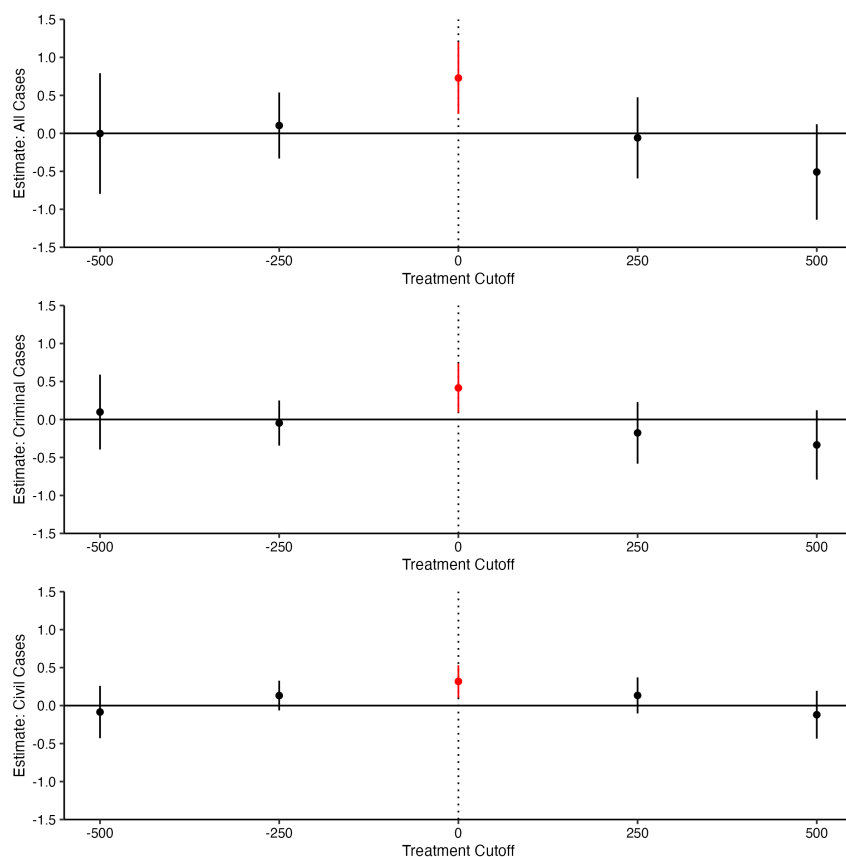


D.4 Results at placebo cut-offs

In Figure A9, I perform placebo tests to show the relationship between the running variable and the case filing at cutoffs other than the true cutoff. To do this, I re-estimate the regression discontinuity

estimates at placebo cutoffs. I generate placebo cutoffs incrementally by adding or subtracting 250 on either side of the true population cutoff that determines the treatment. There are no significant LATE estimates for these placebo cutoffs, showing that there are no significant discontinuities in the outcome for placebo values of the running variable.

Figure A9: Placebo Tests at Different Cutoffs



Note: Results in red indicate the true cutoff, and those in black are computed at placebo cutoffs. Plots indicate bias-corrected point estimate and robust standard errors.

D.5 Robustness using Regression Discontinuity Aggregation

In order to conduct the analysis at the council level, I exclude cases that are filed from litigants in multiple villages. This means that I can only analyse to 36% of cases in the subordinate courts. In this section, I show robustness to including cases filed from multiple villages within the same sub-district (43% of cases in the subordinate courts), through an analysis at the sub-district level using the Regression Discontinuity Aggregation method (Borusyak and Kolesman-Shemer 2025).

In this analysis, I aggregate all the cases filed at the sub-district denoted by i . To estimate the effects of larger sized councils, I first calculate the fraction of treated units in the sub-district (X_i), that is, the ratio of councils that are assigned a larger council to the total number of councils in the sub-district. I instrument this by using the fraction of treated councils that are close to the 1500 cutoff, using the bandwidths estimated (Z_i). Further, to interpret the results as local causal effects at the upper level of aggregation (the sub-district level), I add the RDA controls as suggested in Borusyak and Kolesman-Shemer (2025). In my analysis, these variables are the share of councils within the cutoff relative to the total number of councils in a sub-district (c_1), the average of the running variable within a narrow bandwidth rescaled by their weight (c_2), and the average of the running variables for the treated units within the cutoff rescaled by their weight (c_3).

I use an instrumental variables strategy leveraging RD aggregation using the following specification:

$$\text{First Stage: } X_i = \gamma_0 + \rho_1 Z_i + \gamma_1 \text{Population}_i + \gamma_2 c_{1i} + \gamma_3 c_{2i} + \gamma_4 c_{3i} + \eta_i \quad (4)$$

$$\text{Second Stage: } \text{Cases}_i = \beta_0 + \rho \hat{X}_i + \beta_1 \text{Population}_i + \beta_2 c_{1i} + \beta_3 c_{2i} + \beta_4 c_{3i} + \epsilon_i \quad (5)$$

From Table A13, we see that larger councils lead to greater case filings for all three case types. Since the treatment is a fraction and to make this estimate comparable with the treatment analysed in the paper, I multiple the estimated effects by 0.28 to understand the effect of a 28% increase in the number of treated councils within a sub-district.

Table A14 shows that a 28% increase in the number of treated councils corresponds to a 84% increase in the number of cases filed at the sub-district level. Similarly, a 28% increase in the number of treated councils corresponds to a 74% increase in the number of criminal cases filed and a 103% increase in the number of civil cases filed. While the interpretation of the treatment at the sub-district is slightly different from that analysed in the main paper, it is nevertheless confirms that the effects are not driven due to excluding cases filed from more than one village.

Table A13: Regression Discontinuity Aggregation: Sub-District Level

	All Cases (1)	Criminal Cases (2)	Civil Cases (3)
Share of Large Councils	1,863.303*** (627.210)	1,110.953** (434.596)	724.403*** (265.644)
Population	0.002*** (0.001)	0.001*** (0.0004)	0.001** (0.0003)
c_1	818.270 (542.066)	637.156* (375.600)	177.767 (229.583)
c_2	-2.890 (5.618)	-1.479 (3.893)	-1.424 (2.380)
c_3	-8.701 (9.067)	-6.437 (6.283)	-2.235 (3.840)
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean of DV	619.398	418.893	196.612
First-stage F-stat	80.94	80.94	80.94

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Results from RD Aggregation. Observations at the taluka-year level.

Table A14: Interpreting Magnitude of IV Estimates (Effect of a 28% Increase in X)

Category	Coefficient	0.28*Coefficient	% of Mean DV
All Cases	1863	+521 cases	84%
Criminal Cases	1110	+310 cases	74%
Civil Cases	724	+202 cases	103%

Note: The mean dependent variables for the sample are from Table A13. X is measured as a fraction (0–1).

D.6 Robustness subsetting to low-missingness sub-districts

Another concern with these data is that there are lots of missing cases. This can be assessed by taking advantage of the fact that each case number is assigned in a sequence of numbers in the form of serialized data (Wu et al. 2026). For each sub-district, this allows me to assess how many cases could be missing. On average for each sub-district, it appears that 26% of data is missing. Figure A10 illustrates this in two sub-districts, one evaluated as having low amount of missing data and one with relatively higher missing data.

Figure A10: Using sequence of case numbers to quantify missingness



I replicate the results using the regression discontinuity design, only focusing on the sub-districts where the data is of very high quality: where missingness accounts for fewer than 10% of observed cases. In Table A15, we see that the results are robust in both direction and magnitude on subsetting to the sub-districts wherein the data is high quality and reliable. We lose precision as the sample is now smaller.

Table A15: Regression Discontinuity Aggregation: Courts with high quality data

	All Cases (1)	Criminal Cases (2)	Civil Cases (3)
Share of Large Councils	794.732 (586.736)	679.949 (447.317)	108.258 (172.348)
Population	-0.0002 (0.001)	-0.0002 (0.0004)	0.0001 (0.0002)
c_1	930.367* (516.664)	700.817* (393.895)	230.788 (151.765)
c_2	5.866 (5.177)	4.412 (3.947)	1.448 (1.521)
c_3	-9.709 (8.662)	-7.252 (6.604)	-2.481 (2.544)
District FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes	Yes
Mean of DV	247.825	183.677	63.168
First-stage F-stat	63.6	63.6	63.6

Note: *p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01. Results from RD Aggregation. Observations at the taluka-year level.

D.7 Natural experiment: Newly formed councils

In this section, I analyse an alternate design focusing on newly formed councils. For the main analysis, I focus on councils created before 2011. In this section, I analyse 952 new councils that were formed between 2016 and 2022. These new councils are created by taking the local areas that form the older council, and splitting them into two or more councils. For example, in June 2025, a council comprising three villages: Panchala (Bk), Panchala (Kh) and Guguldosh, in Ramtek, Nagpur, was split into two groups: the first group named Panchala (Bk) comprised of Panchala (Bk) and Panchala (Kh), while the second group named Gugoldoh comprised of the Gugaldoh village²⁴. While some of these newly created councils get assigned a smaller council size (based on the same population thresholds), others get assigned a larger council size with two additional members. For example, before the split, the 3 villages together had a population of 3252, which assigned the council 11 members. Once it split, the first group had a population of 1922 which assigned it a 9-member council, while the second group with a population of 1330 was assigned a 7-member council.

I run the main analysis for these villages only in Table A16. While the results are generally positive for all and criminal cases, they are much smaller and lack statistical significance. This is likely driven by the fact that overall, the newly split councils have a greater representative ratio than before.

To further unpack this, I evaluate the impact of the split by comparing the filing rates of the newly formed councils one year before the establishment, which forms the baseline control, and one year after the establishment of the split council which forms the treatment group. I conduct a simple t-test comparing the two groups, and find that once a council splits into smaller jurisdiction (with a larger representative ratio), the case filing rate increases by 25% ($p = 0.047$).

²⁴Details obtained from Maharashtra Rural Development Ministry Website, <http://bit.ly/4lpGN8u>, Last Accessed on 10 July, 2025. Page archived for reference. Notifications for several other examples can be accessed on the 'Notifications' page here: <http://bit.ly/4IREWsZ>

Table A16: Newly Formed Councils

	All Cases	Criminal Cases	Civil Cases
LATE	0.14 (1.12)	0.23 (0.78)	-0.07 (0.46)
Observations	3809	3809	3809
Observations (bw)	1166	1139	1422
Bandwidth	221	211	255
Mean (control)	1.83	0.99	0.78
Effect (%)	8	23	-9

Note: * $p < 0.1$; ** $p < 0.05$; *** $p < 0.01$. Local linear estimates of average treatment effects (LATE) at cutoff estimated with triangular kernel weights and optimal MSE bandwidth, with 95% robust SEs clustered at the council level.

Observations (bw) denotes the number of observations within the optimal MSE bandwidth and Mean (control) is the control mean within the optimal MSE bandwidth. Each observation is a village-year.

E Additional details

E.1 Rural Economic and Demographic Survey Questions Used

I accessed data from the Rural Economic and Demographic Survey conducted in 2005-06 by obtaining a minimal risk research IRB approval from the University of Wisconsin–Madison. I submitted the same to Dr. Andrew Foster, who shared the restricted data for the 2005-06 years.

Below, I reproduce the exact wording of the questions from which the outcomes are constructed for the difference-in-differences analysis. Each response takes an ordinal outcome taking values between 1 and 4, with 1 being the highest rating for the question [High=1; Medium=2; Low=3; Not aware=4].

1. Honesty: Evaluation of Elected Representatives [Honesty and fairness: p83q3, p83q4]
2. Qualifications: Evaluation of Elected Representatives [Technical qualifications of the candidate: p83q9, p83q10]
3. Solve social problems: Evaluation of Elected Representatives [Ability to solve social problems, such as disputes over land, marriage etc: p83q18, p83q19]
4. Solve local problems: Evaluation of Elected Representatives [Ability to solve local problems such as roads, education, water etc: p83q15, p83q16]

E.2 Interview Questionnaire

In Summer 2025, I collected interviews from 19 council members in Maharashtra. I started with collecting the contact details of currently serving council members in Maharashtra, from which I drew a random sample of 100 contact numbers. The team at *Across India* contacted these council members and asked the following questions:

1. How many years have you been a council member?
2. Do villagers come to you to solve disputes?
 - a. What kinds of disputes do you not attempt to resolve?
 - b. What types of cases do villagers typically approach you to resolve?
 - c. What types of cases do villagers typically not approach you to resolve?
3. There is a property dispute in a family in your village. They approach you for help. How do you help them?
4. There is a murder in your village. You are approached by the family of the deceased for help. How do you help them?
5. Why do you help villagers with their problems?
6. Do you know any lawyers or anyone from the police force? How?

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